



# Hindustan Times

## SAUDI ARAMCO OIL FACILITY ON RED SEA COAST HIT IN FRESH ATTACK

**LONDON/RIYADH:** The Jazan oil refinery, owned by the world's biggest oil company Saudi Aramco, was attacked on Monday and the damage is being ascertained, news agency Reuters said quoting the Financial Times (FT) reported, citing two people with knowledge of the development. In August, Yemen's Houthis claimed to have targeted the refinery in Jazan on the Red Sea coast twice in a week. →P11

## MANIPUR MUSICIAN KILLED IN DELHI FOR OBJECTING TO NOISE

**Karn Pratap Singh**

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**NEW DELHI:** A 54-year-old Manipuri guitarist and music teacher died after he was allegedly assaulted by a group of eight people outside his flat in south-east Delhi's Kilokari village late on Sunday, after he objected to a commotion they were creating near his home, police said.

## Aravalli panel's plea to extend deadline junked

**Utkarsh Anand**

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**NEW DELHI:** Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Monday questioned whether a high-powered committee constituted by the Supreme Court to arrive at a uniform definition of the Aravalli hills and range was seeking to stretch the exercise beyond his tenure, as the court rejected its request for time until February 28, 2027, and directed it to submit its final report by November 30.

"They should have clearly asked for a date after my retirement... appears they are waiting for my retirement. We are not going to allow this," the CJI told additional solicitor general Aishwarya Bhati, who appeared for the Centre. CJI Kant demits office on February 9, 2027. A bench headed by the CJI and comprising Justices Joy-malya Bagchi and V Mohana directed the five-member panel, headed by Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education (ICFRE) director general



Kanchan Devi, to "work day and night" and meet the fresh deadline. The court made clear that no further extension would be granted.

"The high-powered committee has sought an extension till February 28, 2027, with the first stroke of the pen. We reject this plea... the HPC is directed to work day and night and submit its final report by November 30, 2026. We make it clear that no

further extension shall be granted," the bench said in its order.

The court, however, acknowledged the complexity of the exercise and directed the committee to submit interim reports on specific issues as and when its examination progresses. These reports, it said, would allow the court to resolve individual questions without waiting for the entire exercise to conclude.

The committee's request for a six-month extension came after it told the court that its work had shown that the Aravalli landscape could not be adequately defined using a single terrain-based or elevation criterion.

In an interim report filed on August 31, the panel said it was examining spatial, ecological, geological, hydrological, biodiversity, socio-economic and stakeholder evidence before arriving at its conclusions. Field visits and interactions with stakeholders had raised ques-

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## From missiles to radars, DAC clears ₹1.1L-cr defence boost

**Rahul Singh**

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**NEW DELHI:** The defence acquisition council (DAC) on Monday cleared proposals worth ₹1.1 lakh crore to sharpen the capabilities of the armed forces including systems to enhance the war-fighting capability of fighter jets, transport planes and helicopters, new advanced light helicopters and chemical biological radiological and nuclear (CBRN) rece vehicles for the army, and Arudhra radars for the navy, the defence ministry said.

The plan to boost the Indian Air Force's capabilities includes a pilot project to integrate Russian-origin RVV BD long-range air-to-air missiles with Sukhoi-30 fighters, people aware

### THE PLAN INCLUDES A PILOT PROJECT TO INTEGRATE RUSSIAN-ORIGIN RVV BD LONG-RANGE AIR-TO-AIR MISSILES WITH SU-30 FIGHTERS

of the matter said.

The DAC, headed by defence minister Rajnath Singh, also accorded its Acceptance of Necessity (AoN) for a ground-based multi-purpose jammer (GBMPJ) for the IAF, the design, development, and subsequent procurement of marine gas turbines (MGT) for the navy, and high mobility vehi-

cles for the army.

Under India's defence procurement rules, AoN by the council is the first step towards buying military equipment.

"Of the total AoNs accorded, approximately 98% of procurements will be made from the Indian Industry," the defence ministry said.

India has taken several measures to boost self-reliance in the defence manufacturing sector in recent years. These measures include imposing phased import bans on different types of weapons, systems, ammunition, and critical sub-systems and components, creating a separate budget for buying locally made military hardware, increasing foreign direct investment (FDI) from

continued on →9

## AMID ROW, PUNJAB CM, CABINET SKIP SWEARING IN OF HC CHIEF JUSTICE

**CHANDIGARH:** Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann and state cabinet ministers on Monday skipped the swearing-in ceremony of Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra as the Punjab and Haryana high court chief

justice amid a tussle between the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government and Centre over the judicial appointment. →P5



## DRONE SIGHTINGS SUSPEND FLIGHT OPERATIONS AT AMRITSAR AIRPORT

**Neha LM Tripathi**

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**NEW DELHI:** Operations at the Amritsar airport were suspended for more than an hour on Sunday night after the Indian Air Force (IAF) flagged drone activity over the facility, forcing seven aircraft holding for landing to be diverted, officials aware of the matter said. An FIR was registered against unknown people over the incident. →P5

## PICKUP VEHICLE OVERTURNS AFTER HITTING DIVIDER IN U.P., 12 KILLED

**MEERUT:** At least 12 people were killed and 16 injured when a pickup from Badaun overturned on the Eastern Peripheral Expressway in UP's Baghpat district around 1am on Monday after hitting a road divider, police said. The state government announced a compensation of ₹2 lakh each to the families of those killed and ₹50,000 each to the injured. →P7

## BENGAL REDUCES DURGA PUJA GRANT, PUTS CURBS ON DJs, LIQUOR SALE

**KOLKATA:** The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in West Bengal on Monday slashed the grant for Durga Puja committees from ₹1.10 lakh each provided last year by the previous Mamata Banerjee-led government to ₹1 lakh this year, chief minister Suwendu Adhikari said, announcing a complete ban on DJs during the festivities and closure of liquor outlets and bars on Maha Ashtami. →P6

## BYPOLLS FOR 5 ASSEMBLY, 1 LS SEAT ON OCT 6; COUNTING OCT 9

**Himanshi Dahiya**

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**NEW DELHI:** The bypolls to five assembly constituencies and one Lok Sabha seat across Tamil Nadu, Puducherry West Bengal and Assam will be held on October 6 and counting of votes will be held on October 9, the Election Commission announced on Monday. →P6

## GERMAN POLITICAL LANDSCAPE SHIFTS AS FAR-RIGHT CLOSES IN ON STATE POWER

**BERLIN:** The far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD) was poised to be in power in Germany's eastern state of Saxony-Anhalt, far ahead of mainstream rivals. But preliminary results show it has gained 43.8% of the vote to the conservative CDU's 17.2%, falling short of an outright majority needed to govern alone. No far-right party has controlled a German state since WWII. →P11

## NSA charge: HC tells Noida DM to pay ₹5L from salary to student

**Ayesha Arvind**

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**BENGALURU:** The Allahabad High Court has directed that ₹5 lakh compensation be paid to a Delhi University graduate Akriti Chaudhary, who had been in judicial custody for around five months in connection with the April 2026 Noida workers' protest, with the amount to be recovered from the salary of the Gautam Buddha Nagar DM who ordered her preventive detention under the National Security Act (NSA), which the court quashed on September 2.

In its detailed order made public on Monday, a bench of Justices Atul Sreedharan and Achal Sachdev delivered a scathing indictment of the administration's conduct, describing DM Medha Roopam's conduct as

### COURT SAID IAS, IPS OFFICERS MUST REMEMBER THAT THEIR LOYALTY IS TO CONSTITUTION, NOT POLITICAL EXECUTIVE

"worthy of derision" and saying she had sought to "set an example" out of a peaceful student activist to deter others from protesting. The court also directed that its displeasure with the DM and the police be recorded in their service records.

The court also criticised what it described as bureaucratic overreach, saying IAS and IPS officers must remember that their loyalty is to the Constitution and not the political executive. →P2

{ **NARROWING STYLE IN TENNIS** } NO SEMI-FINAL REPRESENTATION AT U.S. OPEN

## Two hands are better? One-handed backhand's 149-yr slam streak ends

**Shahid Judge**

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**MUMBAI:** The 149-year Grand Slam streak of men's singles players with a one-handed backhand reaching the semi-finals has ended at the US Open, after Stefanos Tsitsipas was knocked out in the fourth round by American Ben Shelton.

Shelton beat Tsitsipas 6-2, 6-3, 6-4 on Sunday at Arthur Ashe Stadium, ending a sequence that had stretched back to the first Wimbledon Championships in 1877.

Tsitsipas had launched a social media campaign after the second round, calling for a



Stefanos Tsitsipas lost in the fourth round of the US Open.

AFP

"#Keeponehanderalive" movement and later saying he had a "150-year streak to save".

The end of the streak reflects the steady decline of the one-

handed backhand as modern tennis has become slower, with heavier balls and longer rallies favouring the more stable two-handed stroke. →P14

# NUMBER THEORY

## The real winner of the China+1 strategy? Vietnam

By Sreedev Krishnakumar

Vietnam became the largest exporter to the US in the first half of 2026. It is also a country that has made large gains in exports to the US after 2016, when Donald Trump won his first presidential election and began the US's pivot towards protectionism, first against China and, in his second term, against most US trading partners. What does Vietnam's export success tell us? Are there any particularly important lessons for India?

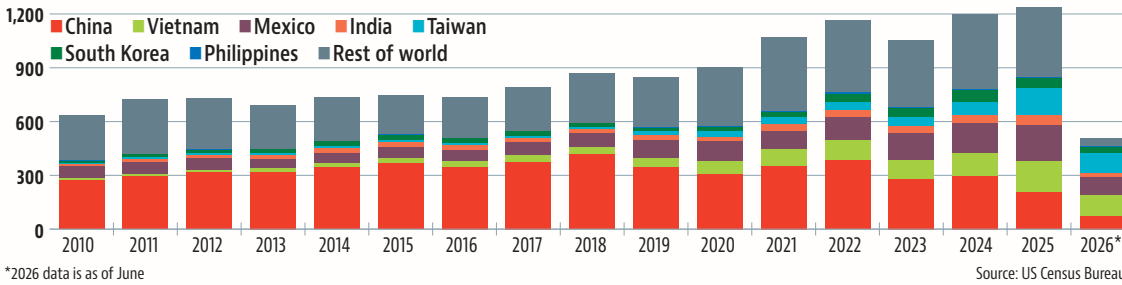


### 1 Total US trade deficit hasn't dipped, its Chinese trade deficit has

The US trade deficit with China has fallen sharply from \$418 billion in 2018 to \$203 billion in 2025. Its overall goods deficit, however, moved in the opposite direction, rising from \$870 billion to a record \$1.23 trillion over the same period. As expected, the US imported more from other countries. By the first half of 2026, America's deficits with Vietnam and Taiwan were already larger than its deficit with China. A 2019 IMF research note had

seen this coming. "A tariff-induced change in a specific trade balance between two countries tends to be offset by changes in bilateral balances with other partners through trade diversion, with little or no impact on the aggregate trade balance", it said. Vietnam's big success in US export market has generated huge tailwinds for its overall export earnings. Its exports in 2025 were higher than India's, even though India's GDP is 7.7 times the size of Vietnam's.

US goods trade deficit by partner country (In USD billion)



### 2 Vietnam has gained across sectors from US's trade diversion away from China

To understand this, HT looked at two-digit HS trade product groups with at least \$20 billion of US imports in 2025, where China supplied at least 20% of the market in 2017 and then lost at least five percentage points of share. The filters are meant to focus on large, economically meaningful markets where China was once an important supplier and then clearly lost share, rather than on small product categories where a sharp percentage-point fall may not amount to much in dollar terms. Nine categories qualified this filtering process. Vietnam emerges as the most consistent beneficiary across labour-intensive goods. Its share rose by nearly 18 percentage points in toys, about 15 points in

furniture and footwear, and six to eight points in apparel. Taiwan's gains were more concentrated in machinery, where its share jumped almost 19 points. India's footprint was smaller overall, but electrical machinery stands out, rising by 5.6 points—second only to Vietnam among the countries analysed—while it also made smaller gains in apparel and iron and steel articles. The reshuffling of US sourcing has therefore produced a clear hierarchy of winners. Vietnam has captured the broadest set of gains, Taiwan and Mexico have dominated particular manufacturing segments, while India's success has so far been narrower and more sector-specific.

#### Who gained as China lost ground in the US market?

Change in each country's share of US imports in selected HS2 product groups, 2017–2025 (in percentage points)

|                                   | China  | Vietnam | Mexico | Taiwan | India |
|-----------------------------------|--------|---------|--------|--------|-------|
| Machinery (HS 84)                 | -24.46 | 7.59    | 7.2    | 18.85  | 0.38  |
| Electrical Machinery (HS 85)      | -25.68 | 8.92    | 0.46   | 3.17   | 5.58  |
| Furniture (HS 94)                 | -30.47 | 14.98   | 2.98   | -0.16  | 0.78  |
| Toys and sports equipment (HS 95) | -28.06 | 17.89   | 2.11   | 0.47   | 0.4   |
| Knitted apparel (HS 61)           | -18.18 | 5.94    | -1.27  | -0.22  | 1.58  |
| Footwear (HS 64)                  | -29.92 | 14.72   | 1.22   | -0.11  | 0.17  |
| Non-knitted apparel (HS 62)       | -21.26 | 7.76    | -0.59  | -0.04  | 2.04  |
| Plastics (HS 39)                  | -9.91  | 5.62    | 2.46   | -0.16  | 0.85  |
| Iron and steel articles (HS 73)   | -10.98 | 2.73    | 2.54   | 0.04   | 2.76  |

Product groups are HS2 categories with at least \$20 billion of US imports in 2025, where China accounted for at least 20% of US imports in 2017 and subsequently lost at least 5 percentage points of market share by 2025. Qualifying categories are sorted by the size-adjusted decline in China's US import share, calculated using 2025 US import value and China's percentage-point loss in market share, from largest to smallest.

Source: US Census Bureau

### 3 Vietnam's trade engagement with China has increased consistently

Vietnam's rise in the US market also came with deeper trade ties to China. Between 2017 and 2024, US imports from Vietnam nearly tripled, while China's exports to Vietnam more than doubled. More importantly, Chinese exports of intermediate goods to Vietnam rose by about 86%. This suggests that although some production may have shifted out of China, China remains an important supplier further up the value chain.

#### Vietnam's US gains came alongside deeper China trade (2017=100)

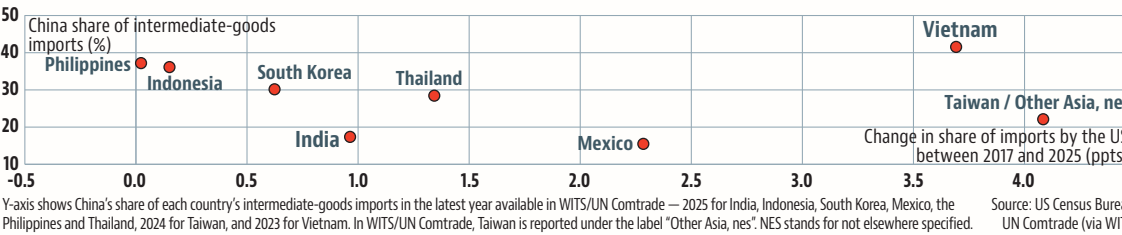


### 4 Lessons for India: Chinese engagement matters, but so does the domestic economy

Export success stories are often read mechanically. Sometimes they are seen as driven by cheap labour, sometimes by FDI or economic linkage with one particular country. Vietnam's recent success story shows why the reality is more nuanced than such simplistic claims. China does have a large share in Vietnam's intermediate imports, but it is not the only

country with a large Chinese share in intermediate imports. Not all of them have been able to increase exports to the US in the post-Trump era. And some, such as chip-exporting Taiwan, have increased exports to the US without raising Chinese imports. This is where playing by a country's comparative advantage becomes important.

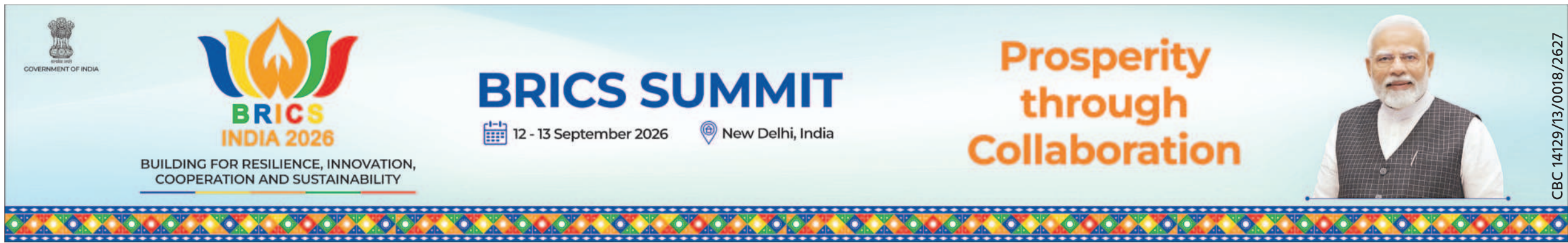
#### China+1 does not necessarily mean leaving China behind





# Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.



55 MORE STATIONS  
TO MONITOR AIR  
ACROSS DELHI, NCR  
CITIES BY END-2026

Jasjev Gandhiok

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**NEW DELHI:** The ambient air quality monitoring network across Delhi-NCR is set to become significantly denser, with 55 more continuous ambient air quality monitoring stations to be added by the end of this year, officials said. The expansion will take the number of operational stations in Delhi and NCR cities in UP, Haryana and Rajasthan from 102 to 157.

HC ORDERS ASSAM  
TO PAY ₹2L OVER  
EXPULSION OF  
WOMAN TO B'DESH

Utpal Parashar

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**GUWAHATI:** The Gauhati high court has directed the Assam government to pay ₹2 lakh as interim compensation to the husband of Mumtaz Begum, a Bengali-speaking Muslim who was expelled to Bangladesh after a foreigners tribunal declared her a foreign national. The compensation, the bench said, would not limit the petitioner from seeking more relief from a civil court. →P2

## PG owner held, officials face action

Retired IAF sergeant and his brother built four illegal floors despite being aware of risks to building's foundation, says FIR

Karn Pratap Singh, Hemani Bhandari, Paras Singh and Saloni Bhatia

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**NEW DELHI:** Delhi Police on Monday arrested the owner of a five-storey building that housed Delhi University students and crumpled a day earlier, as the toll in the tragedy climbed to seven and questions swirled about the negligence of the municipal authorities and state government.

Hariram Bansal, a 81-year-old former airforce sergeant, was arrested from Rajasthan's Bhiwadi. His wife Urmila Gupta, 75, and son Mahesh Gupta, 52, were also arrested. Bansal and his wife were sent to 14-day judicial custody. His son, whom police said administered the building, was sent to two-day police custody.

The order was passed by Judicial Magistrate First Class Bhavya Kharail after all three



Personnel clear debris from the site of the five-storey building collapse in Satya Niketan in Delhi on Monday.

SANCHIT KHANNA/HT PHOTO

were produced at her residence.

The government suspended five Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) officials as the Delhi High Court ordered a high-level inquiry into the incident, the second such building collapse in the Capital in less than four months.

Rescuers worked through the night to pull people buried

under mounds of rubble and chunks of concrete as plumes of smoke blanketed the neighbourhood where cramped buildings flouting multiple guidelines house tens of thousands of students from DU, where official accommodation is dwarfed by the annual pupil intake.

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### HC SEEKS ACCOUNTABILITY FROM MCD AND DU

The Delhi High Court on Monday directed the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to conduct an inquiry at the highest executive level into the Satya Niketan building collapse, asking it to determine whether the structure had been constructed with valid permissions and fix

responsibility on officials if lapses were found. The court said the incident was "unfortunate" and prima facie suggested that responsibility for such mishaps also lied with MCD and university authorities for ensuring compliance with building bye-laws and other regulations.

### SEVEN KILLED: FIVE ARE STUDENTS, 2 ARE LABOURERS

Ridhima Gupta and Aadiya Khatwani

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**NEW DELHI:** Five of the seven killed in the building collapse in Satya Niketan were Delhi University students, including two who had returned from trips back home — one just a few hours before the incident — for celebrating Rakhshabhandhan. Another student who died, a 20-year-old, had moved into the hostel a just couple of days ago.

The victims of the collapse also included two labourers — a 75-year-old and a 30-year-old. All victims were male.

ALTERNATIVE-FUEL  
VEHICLES OUTSELL  
PETROL CARS FOR  
FIRST TIME IN AUG

**BENGALURU:** Sales of alternative-fuel passenger vehicles outpaced petrol-powered cars in India in August for the first time, the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA) said on Monday, as the West Asia war raised oil prices and concerns over higher-ethanol-content fuel. Alternative-fuel models, including CNG, hybrid and electric models, accounted for nearly 42% of passenger-vehicle sales, while petrol vehicles stood at about 41%, said FADA. →P12

1951 TO SERVE AS  
BASE YEAR FOR  
MANIPUR NRC:  
STATE MINISTER

Thomas Ngangom

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**IMPHAL:** Manipur home minister Govindas Konhoujam told the assembly on Monday that 1951 will be the base year for the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in the northeastern province, underlining that the state government was determined to push through the controversial exercise in the strife-torn region. →P5

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{ BUSINESS } BOOST FOR EXPORTERS  
**UK recognises India's carbon credit scheme**



The UK has formally recognised India's Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS) as a qualifying carbon-pricing mechanism under its Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM), potentially easing the carbon-tax burden on Indian exports of steel, aluminium and cement and likely setting a precedent for the EU, people familiar with the matter said. After prolonged technical discussions, the UK government recently communicated to New Delhi that it had assessed the details of India's CCTS and formally accepted it, the people said, requesting anonymity. The development comes after the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) was operationalised on July 15, while the treatment of CBAM remained unresolved and was a major concern for both sides. A government official confirmed the UK's acceptance of CCTS, describing it as a "positive" development.

{ WORLD } AFTER UK RETURN  
**Harry, Meghan pvt citizens: King Charles**



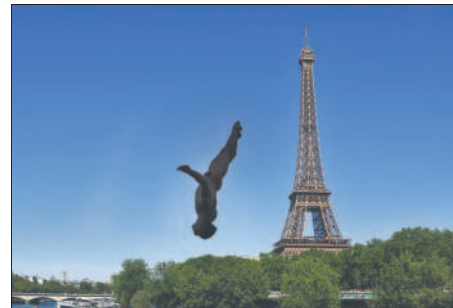
King Charles authorised a letter to British officials on Monday confirming that his youngest son Harry and his wife Meghan remain non-working royals following their return to the UK. The letter, which was shared with Harry's team, said that after the two stepped down from official royal duties in 2020 they "are no longer working Members of The Royal Family". "It follows that there is no change to the current status of the Duke and Duchess of Sussex... The charitable work of the Duke and Duchess is a personal matter for them both and undertaken in their private capacity. In short, their position is akin to private citizens with commercial and charitable interests," the letter said. Prince Harry and his family arrived back in Britain late last month, six years after quitting royal duties and moving to the US.

{ MY INDIA } IN SAGAR DISTRICT  
**MP hooch toll increases to 20; 30 booked, 10 arrested**



The death toll from the consumption of spurious liquor in Madhya Pradesh's Sagar district climbed to 20 on Monday, officials aware of the matter said, and added that 112 people have been hospitalised so far. Police have registered an FIR against 30 individuals, including the liquor contractor, for culpable homicide not amounting to murder and arrested 10 people. The victims had consumed the spurious liquor on the intervening night of September 5 and September 6. According to the FIR lodged at Banda police station, villager Anoop Singh Lodhi alleged that around eight people were selling liquor illegally in his village. "We are awaiting test reports before taking further action against traders. Local contractors and suppliers have been booked for selling cheap liquor, which led to mass consumption," said the superintendent of police Anurag Sujania. The victims reported symptoms including nausea, vomiting, memory loss, high fever, and severe headaches.

{ WORLD } AFTER BAPS VISIT  
**Eiffel Tower closed after staff protests**



The Eiffel Tower was closed on Monday because of a strike by staff over the removal of female colleagues during a visit by a Hindu religious group, workers and management said. The visit came on the same day as a cultural boat procession on the Seine organised by the Bochasanwasi Akshar Purushottam Swaminarayan Sanstha (BAPS) spiritual movement. In a statement, Eiffel Tower staff condemned "professional instructions that led to female employees being sidelined, replaced and made invisible because of their sex" during the visit by the delegation. The operating company that runs the Paris landmark, SETE, acknowledged that the Hindu delegation had requested the visit be organised so as to limit "interactions with women" and said that "these conditions should not have been accepted". AFP

{ SPORT } DRUBBING IN ENGLAND  
**PCB starts inquiry after player recall**



The Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) is conducting an internal "disciplinary" inquiry against unnamed players after recalling seven cricketers and two coaches midway through the tour of England. "The PCB has initiated an internal disciplinary inquiry following media reports concerning discipline and conduct, which are currently being reviewed internally," its media director Amir Mir said on X Monday. There was speculation in local media that the PCB had obtained data from the mobile phones of Imam-ul-Haq and Mohammad Rizwan before both players flew back to Pakistan. According to Geo News, the phones of both players were taken into possession by the team's security officer after Pakistan lost the second test by 194 runs at Lord's. The news channel said phones were handed back to the players hours before they left UK. Pakistan trail the three-match series 2-0.



The workers' agitation demanding wage hike turned violent in Noida in April.

## HC slams Noida DM over 'sham' NSA detention

Ayesha Arvind  
letters@hindustantimes.com

**BENGALURU:** The Allahabad High Court has directed that ₹5 lakh compensation be paid to 25-year-old Delhi University graduate Akriti Chaudhary, who had been in judicial custody for around five months in connection with the April 2026 Noida workers' protest, with the amount to be recovered from the salary of the Gautam Buddha Nagar district magistrate who ordered her preventive detention under the National Security Act (NSA), which the court quashed on September 2.

In its detailed order made public on Monday, a bench of Justices Atul Sreedharan and Achal Sachdev delivered a scathing indictment of the administration's conduct, describing district magistrate Medha Roopam's conduct as "worthy of derision" and saying she had sought to "set an example" out of a peaceful student activist to deter others from protesting. The court also directed that its displeasure with the DM and the police be recorded in their service records.

The court also criticised what it described as bureaucratic overreach, saying IAS and IPS officers must remember that their loyalty is to the Constitution and not the political executive. "They (civil servants) should realise that their loyalty is towards the Constitution and not the political executive, and the honesty and impartiality are towards the people whom they serve while bearing in mind at all times that they are the servants who serve the people, the masters in a democracy," the court said.

The court warned that officers who forget this risk reducing Uttar Pradesh to "an Orwellian Dystopia." The bench scrutinised the evidence relied upon by the administration to detain Chaudhary, including WhatsApp chats, videos, case diary entries and message timestamps retrieved from her phone, and found that the record did not support the prosecution's version of events. A key issue was a notice issued to Chaudhary under Section 130 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), under which police can require a person to execute a bond for "good behaviour" in certain circumstances. The police claimed Chaudhary was

served the notice on April 12, requiring her to furnish a ₹50,000 bond, and was arrested only after she refused. Chaudhary, represented by senior advocate Colin Gonsalves, had argued that she had actually been taken into custody on the evening of April 11 and was never given a genuine opportunity to furnish the bond.

The High Court found that the General Diary entry number mentioned in the notice could only have been generated after her arrest, suggesting that the notice itself was prepared retrospectively.

"Mentioning the G.D. number in the notice under Section 130 of the BNSS reveals that the Petitioner was already arrested and the procedure of giving a notice under Section 130 of the BNSS was ex post facto the arrest and nothing more than a sham," the court said.

When the State was asked to explain the "visible fabrication in the record", the court said, "no answer" was forthcoming.

The bench also found that the WhatsApp messages and videos produced by the State did not contain "a single message" or video showing that Chaudhary had incited people to riot, commit arson or damage public or private property.

The violence that erupted on April 13 therefore could not, on the material placed before the court, be attributed to a conspiracy allegedly hatched by Chaudhary, it said.

The court said preventive detention under the NSA is an "exception" and cannot be used merely to keep someone incarcerated because they might otherwise secure bail in an ordinary criminal case. It stressed that the exercise of such extraordinary power directly affects the right to life and personal liberty under Article 21 of the Constitution and "cannot be exercised lightly on the basis of surmises, biases, conjectures and opinions". The court also cautioned against restricting peaceful protests merely on the assumption that they could lead to a breach of peace. "Preventing people from gathering in public spaces or agitating their rights on the grounds of assumed breach of peace," it said, would amount to "throwing the baby out of the bath water".

Instead, the State should train its police force to manage large gatherings and use videography to ensure accountability when violence occurs, the court said.

## 5 killed in US cargo plane crash

An Amazon Prime Air cargo plane overran a runway at Miami International Airport, crashed into vehicles and caught fire on Sunday. The identities of the deceased were not immediately known.



A Prime Air cargo plane after crashing into vehicles as it overran the runway at the Miami International Airport on Sunday. AFP

**AFTER TOUCHDOWN...**  
The Amazon plane ploughed across a road used by warehouse workers and other businesses surrounding the airport. Apart from the five dead, five people were also injured, three of them critically.

**UNDER INVESTIGATION LENS**  
**Did the plane touch down too far down the runway?**  
Typically, the landing zone is within the first 3,000 feet of a runway. Aviation safety experts said if it was beyond that area, the plane should have aborted the landing and gone around for another attempt.



**Did the plane fail to flare?**  
Videos posted online show the Amazon plane floating above the runway for an extended period without flaring the nose upward to force the main landing gear onto the ground.



## KEY SAFETY EQUIPMENT MISSING

The Miami airport is not equipped with arresting systems, beds of lightweight, crushable material at the end of a runway, that have been installed at more than 120 airports in the US to safely stop planes that go past the end of a runway.

## WHICH PLANE WAS INVOLVED?

A 32-year-old Boeing 767, which was originally built to carry passengers before being converted to a cargo plane in 2015. The aircraft is no longer in production as a commercial aircraft but is still widely flown, mainly for cargo services and as military refuelling aircraft. Sunday's flight was operated by 21 Air, a cargo carrier based in North Carolina.

## CARGO FLIGHT RISK

Freight planes make up only a small part of commercial air traffic, but cargo operations have been prone to proportionally more crashes over the years, partly because flights can be longer and planes are older.

## AI lung drug shows anti-ageing potential

Bloomberg  
letters@hindustantimes.com

An experimental lung disease drug developed using artificial intelligence showed promise in reversing biological signs of aging, pointing to broader potential use of the treatment, according to its developer.

In a mid-stage study, Insilico Medicine's drug rentosertib helped reduce biological age as measured by six different aging clocks examining chemical changes in the body, according to an analysis published in Nature Biotechnology on Monday. Those who were given a placebo saw little change in their biological age on those same clocks, the Hong Kong-listed company said.

"If your biological age is lower, you are likely to die later," the AI drug discovery startup's Chief Executive Officer, Alex Zhavoronkov, said in an interview. He cautioned that the results are still early and the long-term health effects of the drug on larger groups of people are unknown. The analysis included 42 patients with a chronic lung disease.

**THE RESULTS ARE STILL EARLY AND THE LONG-TERM HEALTH EFFECTS OF THE DRUG ON LARGER GROUPS OF PEOPLE ARE NOT YET KNOWN**

the study — developed by teams at Insilico, Harvard University, China's Peking University and others — each use different metrics and methods. While longevity enthusiasts have long embraced the repurposing of existing medications to delay aging, efforts to develop novel anti-aging drugs have often ended in failure. But with the advent of GLP-1 treatments whose benefits now appear to extend far beyond weight loss and diabetes, major pharmaceutical players are increasingly showing interest in the field. Companies including Insilico have chosen to focus on dual-use therapies that can tackle age-related ailments while helping people live longer along the way. The latest study is part of a Phase 2 trial that also measured rentosertib's efficacy in treating idiopathic pulmonary fibrosis. Rentosertib is currently in a late-stage clinical trial in China for the incurable lung disease.

Insilico plans to run similar analyses for at least half of the drugs in its pipeline. AI promises to compress drug research timelines, increase chances of success and propose ideas humans may not otherwise have.

Insilico first identified the target behind rentosertib as one implicated in aging with an AI tool that trawls through large amounts of data to rank potential targets. It then designed and refined the drug using another tool that screens molecules virtually and suggest ways to optimize them. For its analysis, Insilico collected blood from patients at various time points during the trial and partnered with external researchers to analyze changes in proteins. Four weeks after the initial dose, patients taking rentosertib saw their average biological age dropped by as much as six years, although the benefit narrowed later in the trial. The study offers a template for future anti-aging drug development, Zhavoronkov said. While it's currently impossible to win regulatory approval specifically for aging, he suggested the results would open the door for doctors to prescribe or test rentosertib for aging — or age-related diseases — once the drug is approved for other uses.

## HC to Assam: Pay ₹2 lakh over woman's expulsion to B'desh

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**GUWAHATI:** The Gauhati high court has directed the Assam government to pay ₹2 lakh as interim compensation to the husband of Mumtaz Begum, a Bengali-speaking Muslim who was expelled to Bangladesh after a foreigners tribunal declared her a foreign national.

This is likely the first instance where a court has imposed a cost on the state for declaring someone a foreigner and pushing them to Bangladesh, in violation of deportation rules. A bench of justices Kalyan Rai Surana and Susmita Phukan Khound passed the order while hearing a habeas corpus petition filed by Begum's husband Mujammel Hoque, a resident of Juria in Nagaon district. "As the detenu (the woman) has been expelled out of India without providing any information to the petitioner (the woman's husband) or any adult family member... as an interim palliative measure, the court is inclined to direct the Assam government to pay an interim compensation of ₹2 lakh to the petitioner," the bench said in its order dated September 3. The compensation, the bench said, would not limit the petitioner from seeking more relief from a civil court. It directed the state government to pay the amount within 60 days.

The division bench also impleaded the ministry of external affairs in the case and said it would direct it to "make an endeavour to have the woman located in Bangladesh and to expatriate her to India". Hoque moved the high court in June after failing to locate his wife at the detention camp meant for people declared foreign nationals by the foreigners tribunals, at Matia in Goalpara district.

Foreigners tribunals are quasi-judicial bodies unique to Assam that adjudicates on matters of citizenship of those marked as suspected foreigners by the border police or those listed as doubtful voters (D-voters) in electoral rolls. The Nagaon tribunal declared Begum, who says she was born in Rupahihat in Nagaon district in December 1982, a foreigner in 2019, despite her producing documents showing that her grandfather's name was in voter lists prior to 1971 — the cut-off year for citizenship in Assam. Begum challenged the order in the high court. In April, the court set aside the order and sent the case back to the tribunal for a "fresh decision". But within minutes of appearing before the tribunal on May 30, Begum was arrested by police. She was kept at the Juria police station that night before taking her to the detention centre at Matia the next day.

It was only after the habeas corpus plea came up for hearing in late June, the authorities informed that Begum was handed over to Border Security Force and "sent back to Bangladesh" on the midnight of June 14. The bench noted that Begum was not informed of the May 30 order, observing that by not providing copy of the tribunal's order to Begum or her family members or failure to inform them about her expulsion, were procedural lapses on part of the state machinery and police. Questioning the timing of the tribunal's order and Begum's subsequent arrest, the high court asked the Assam home department to order an inquiry. "The state machinery, acting in tandem, had prevented the detenu to exhaust her right to move this court by way of a writ petition to challenge the impugned opinion dated May 30. Thus, only when this writ petition was filed, the petitioner could come to know that the detenu was expelled from the country," the order said. In light of the proceedings, the bench directed district superintendents of police to ensure that declared foreign nationals are informed of tribunal orders before being taken into custody. An adult family member must also be informed before the person is removed from the district. The matter will be heard next on September 24.

# MY BENGALURU

{ SPECIAL INTENSIVE REVISION }

## 61-yr-old listed as dead among electors flagging flawed notices

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**BENGALURU/MANGALURU/ BIDAR:** Donald Joseph Rego (61) had no reason to prove that he was alive. Until the draft electoral roll published on August 24 under the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) told him otherwise.

The 61-year-old from Mangaluru South constituency's Bejai discovered his name was missing from the draft rolls and was listed instead under the "dead" category of the Absent, Shifted, Duplicate, Dead and Others (ASDDO) list.

The discovery kicked off a series of fruitless visits to election officials, said Rego. "I kept going from one office to another, and instead of taking responsibility, the officials kept directing me to someone else," he said, alleging that the assistant electoral officer (AERO) blamed the

booth-level officer (BLO), who in turn told him to speak to the data entry operator who had uploaded the information through the SIR mobile application.

His record was eventually corrected. He received a revised document on Monday and is now waiting for his physical voter ID.

Over 4.3 million voters have received notices over discrepancies in their electoral records so far under the exercise, which is currently in the claims and objections phase. The hearings began across the state on September 5 and will continue until September 23.

What looks like a database exercise on paper is increasingly being worked out in homes, government offices and hearing centres, where voters are searching for old certificates and trying to understand why records they considered settled have sud-



**Donald Joseph Rego (61) was forced to make multiple visits to election officials after being listed under the deceased category.** SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

denly become questions.

In Jayanagar, a voter was flagged because the recorded age gap between him and his sibling was less than nine months. The family is preparing to explain why two children were born as twins.

Hegganahalli resident Nagaraju Shivappa's BLO asked him to produce another docu-

ment along with Aadhaar. Nagaraju did not have an SSLC certificate or a passport and was advised to apply for a Permanent Residence Certificate (PRC). He said he spent five days trying to submit the application. "The portal kept showing an error. I would try again, but the application would not go through." He was then asked to attend a hearing on Monday and explain his circumstances.

PRC applications have themselves surfaced as hurdles in some cases. Technical and server problems have been reported on platforms including Atal Seva Sindhu, Bengaluru One, Karnataka One and Gram One. Staff at rural centres have continued trying to upload applications despite the errors.

The questions have also reached voters whose electoral participation is relatively recent.

Independent journalist Rohini Mohan received a notice flagging

an alleged technical discrepancy even though there was not change in her name in previous records. "My name is Rohini in the 2002 voter roll, father's name Mohan, who is apparently a different person than Rohini Mohan whose father is Mohan," she said.

Journalist Samar Halarnkar discovered that he and his 90-year-old mother received notices after someone circulated the list in a WhatsApp group instead getting a notice from the BLO. The Election Commission had matched his EPIC number with the 2002 electoral roll, yet both names had been flagged.

The problems extend beyond Bengaluru. About 52,000 voters in the coastal districts remain unmapped. Additional Deputy Commissioner of Dakshina Kannada Raju K said the issue affected people working abroad as well as migrants living and working in the district.



B Nagendra

**VALMIKI CORP PMLA CASE: ED AGAIN QUESTIONS FORMER MINISTER**

Press Trust of India

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**BENGALURU:** The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Monday recorded the statement of former minister B Nagendra in a money laundering investigation linked to the alleged misappropriation of funds from the Valmiki Corporation, officials said.

The 54-year-old MLA's statement was recorded under the provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) at the ED's office here, they said.

The federal probe agency had earlier questioned Nagendra, a Congress MLA from Bellary Rural, in this case and arrested him in July 2024. It subsequently filed a chargesheet against him.

According to officials, the fresh round of questioning is understood to be linked to alleged irregularities in the Karnataka Maharishi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation Limited (KMVSTDC) and the contents of a chargesheet filed by the CBI in this case in June.

The legislator resigned from the Karnataka Cabinet in late August for the second time against the backdrop of the opposition pressure regarding his alleged involvement in the case. He had also resigned in 2024 after the case came to light and was subsequently arrested by the ED. He later secured bail.

After resigning a second time, he accused the opposition BJP of "spreading lies" about the alleged Valmiki Corporation scam. Nagendra asserted that he resigned to protect the government from embarrassment.



**Siddaramaiah was felicitated and presided over the event at Palace Grounds in Bengaluru on Sunday.** X/@SIDDARAMAIAH

## Major AHINDA faces skip event led by ex-CM

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**BENGALURU:** Former chief minister Siddaramaiah on Sunday presided over a major gathering of AHINDA (Alpasankhyataru, Hindulidavaru and Dalitaru) leaders in Bengaluru. Three key AHINDA leaders, however, were not present at the event. Speaking to reporters on Monday, they sought to downplay their absence.

Public works minister Satish Jarkiholi, housing minister BZ Zameer Ahmed Khan and former minister HC Mahadevappa, all prominent figures associated with the AHINDA movement, were absent from the silver jubilee celebrations of the Karnataka State Backward Castes Federation at Palace Grounds.

Jarkiholi confirmed he was not invited. "I was not invited, so I did not go. This is not a serious issue. AHINDA is not anyone's property. Anyone can claim the AHINDA identity," he said.

Their absence, particularly Jarkiholi's, comes as the Congress prepares for the political contest that will precede the 2028 Assembly elections.

Jarkiholi has emerged as an important backward class voice in his own right. Siddarama-

**SIDDARAMAIAH USED THE EVENT TO PUSH THE DEMAND FOR 75% QUOTAS FOR AHINDA IN GOVT JOBS AND LEGISLATURE**

iah's son Yathindra Siddaramaiah had earlier projected him as a future leader, while Jarkiholi has openly expressed his aspiration to become Chief Minister in 2028.

Siddaramaiah used the gathering to call for the demand for 75% reservation for Dalits, backward classes and minorities in government jobs and the Lok Sabha and state assemblies to be intensified.

The 78-year-old leader also announced that he would not contest the 2028 Assembly elections. "The electoral system has become very expensive and has deteriorated. I have also grown old," Siddaramaiah said.

Shivakumar separately sought to claim AHINDA as part of the Congress's political identity. "AHINDA is ours. Congress ideology is AHINDA ideology. The Congress will continue to uphold its ideology towards the backward classes," he said.

## Minor held for raping, killing 45-yr-old: Cops

Hirekop Rajan Samuel

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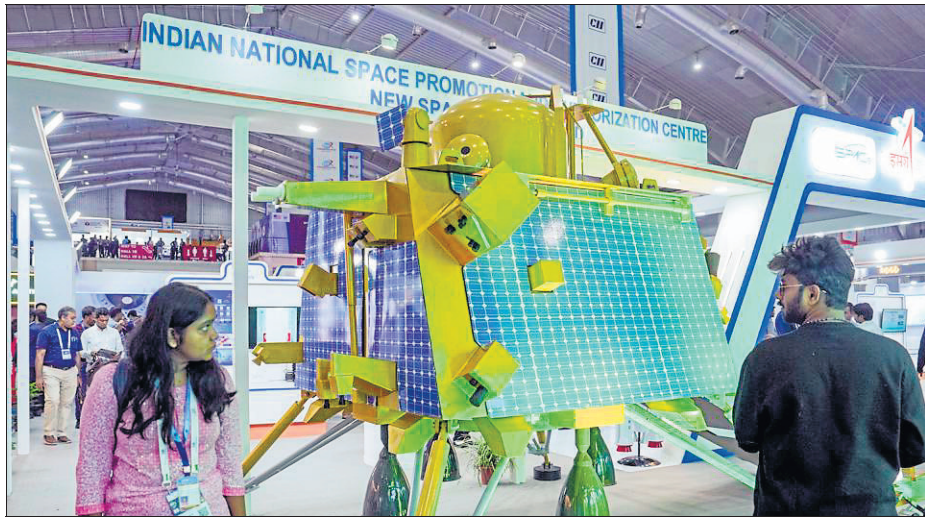
**BELAGAVI:** A 17-year-old boy was detained for allegedly raping and killing a 45-year-old woman in Chitradurga district on Sunday, police said on Monday.

Hiriyur Rural police inspector Manjunath AH said that the woman reportedly called her son on Sunday evening and alleged that the minor had raped her at her house. Upon arriving there, he found her in seriously injured. She was rushed to a nearby hospital, where she was declared dead.

"The woman resisted the sexual assault, following which the minor physically overpowered and raped her. He later attacked her with a machete, causing fatal injuries," said the inspector.

He said preliminary enquiries indicated that the minor found out that the victim had summoned her son and allegedly returned to her house with his father and brothers. He allegedly attacked her before fleeing. Police have registered a case under relevant BNS sections against five people, including the minor and his relatives, and have begun a probe. Investigators suspect that the weapon used in the attack was destroyed.

## 9th Bengaluru Space Expo opens



**Visitors at the inaugural session of 9th Bengaluru Space Expo 2026 on Monday.** PTI

## High court denies anticipatory bail to former KPSC chairman

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**BENGALURU:** The Karnataka high court on Monday refused pre-arrest bail to former Karnataka Public Service Commission chairman Shivashankarappa Sahukar in the case involving alleged irregularities in the hiring of veterinary officers.

Justice S Vishwajith Shetty, while hearing Sahukar's petition, said the alleged misconduct raised questions about what happens to candidates who spend years preparing for competitive examinations only to find the recruitment process compromised.

"Compared to others, the role attributed to the petitioner appears to be more serious. The documents placed by the government are against the petitioner," the court observed.

The court also questioned the effect such irregularities could have on candidates and their families.

"If the system is allowed to function like this, what will happen to talented students? What will be the fate of those families whose members appeared for



Shivashankarappa Sahukar

the examination?" the court asked.

It further observed that such incidents could erode public confidence in the KPSC. "The confidence of people in KPSC itself is observed," the court observed, according to the proceedings.

The court was also told that the investigation had found links between several candidates and Sahukar. Prosecutors alleged that Basavaraj Kannale, one of the accused arrested in the case, had been in contact with the former KPSC chairman.

Special Public Prosecutor BN Jagadish told the court that investigators had found communications between the

accused and alleged beneficiaries of the recruitment process. He also alleged that Sahukar used a private mobile phone to communicate with beneficiaries until about 8pm on the day of the examination.

The prosecution alleged that Sahukar's family members had also facilitated the alleged misuse of the KPSC system and that officials and intermediaries involved in the recruitment process were connected to the accused.

"Officials and intermediaries were in contact with the accused. The circumstances emerging from the investigation require a detailed probe," the prosecution argued while opposing the bail petition.

The court, after hearing the prosecution's case and the submissions on behalf of Sahukar, dismissed his anticipatory bail petition. The court's observations came as the Criminal Investigation Department continues its investigation into the alleged recruitment irregularities.

The prosecution said the probe had already resulted in the arrest of IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar and Kannale.

## Murder accused shot in leg during escape bid

Press Trust of India

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**CHIKKAMAGALURU:** A 27-year-old murder accused was shot in the leg on Monday after he allegedly attacked a constable and attempted to flee from custody in this district, police said.

The incident occurred near Lingapura village on the N R

Pura Road, they said.

The accused, identified as Umesh Naik, is the prime accused in the murder of 32-year-old repeat offender Kulli Kiran, who was killed in Ramenakoppa in Shivamogga district on Sunday.

According to police, a team from the Tunganagar police station traced Naik to the N R

Pura area and was transporting him back to Shivamogga when he turned belligerent near Lingapura village in Chikkamagaluru district.

Naik allegedly attacked police constable Thammanna on his left shoulder with a chain in a bid to escape, said police officers.

Tunganagar Police Inspector

K T Gururaj issued warnings to Naik to surrender. When the suspect ignored the warnings and continued his escape attempt, Gururaj opened fire from his service pistol, injuring Naik in his left leg, a senior police officer said.

Both the injured and constable Thammanna were admitted to a local hospital, he said.

## 75% QUOTA IN PLANS FOR RURAL ASPIRANTS IN GOVT COURSES

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

**BENGALURU:** The Karnataka government has proposed a 7.5 per cent reservation in government seats for eligible rural candidates from government schools and another 7.5 per cent for those who studied in rural institutions.

The proposal is part of draft amendments to the Karnataka Selection of Candidates for Admission to Government Seats in Professional Educational Institutions Rules, 2006, notified by the Higher Education Department on September 5 and shared with the press on Monday.

Under the proposed amendment, out of the 15 per cent government-seat quota, 7.5 per cent would be reserved horizontally for eligible rural candidates who studied from Class 1 to 10 in government schools or government pre-university colleges managed by the School Education Department and located in rural areas of Karnataka.

The remaining 7.5 per cent would be reserved for eligible rural candidates who studied from Class 1 to 10 in government institutions or schools situated in rural areas of the state, irrespective of whether they are government-run.

The government said the draft rules were being published for the information of persons likely to be affected, and invited objections and suggestions, which will be considered if received within 15 days of the draft's publication in the Official Gazette.

The proposed rules, to be called the Karnataka Selection of Candidates for Admission to Government Seats in Professional Educational Institutions (Amendment) Rules, 2026, will come into force from the date of their publication in the Official Gazette. The amendment has been proposed under Section 14 of the Karnataka Educational Institutions (Prohibition of Capitation Fee) Act, 1984.

**THE GOVT INVITED SUGGESTIONS FROM CONCERNED STAKEHOLDERS FOR 15 DAYS AFTER THE DRAFT NOTIFICATION'S PUBLICATION**

## PATNA HC ISSUES NOTICES TO K'TAKA COPS OVER LAPSES DURING ARREST

Press Trust of India

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**PATNA:** The Patna high court has issued notices to Karnataka police and administrative officials over alleged procedural lapses in taking two Bihar residents into custody from the eastern state's Vaishali district last month.

As per a writ petition filed by one Shatrudhan Prasad Singh, Karnataka Police on August 12 took Alok Ambani and Aman Kumar into custody without informing local police, and took them away without obtaining transit remand from a court. The division bench took strict note of alleged procedural lapses.

Court directed both Bihar and Karnataka state authorities to file affidavits "giving entire narration of the manner in which and reasons for which these two persons were taken away".

## Govt to review online pharma sales

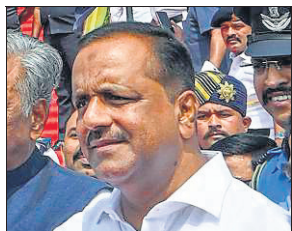
Arun Dev

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**BENGALURU:** Karnataka will review how medicines are sold online and stored at warehouses after the state's Food and Drug Administration seized drugs worth about ₹4.2 lakh from two facilities linked to a major e-commerce company, state health minister UT Khader said on Monday.

The FDA seized medicines worth ₹2.45 lakh from a premises in Tattanahalli and drugs worth another ₹1.57 lakh from a facility in the Devanahalli Aerospace area during raids on Sunday. The medicines were being stored without the required licence, Khader said.

The raids have now led the state government to examine whether existing oversight is adequate for medicines sold through online platforms. "I have called a meeting with officials on Tuesday to discuss why medicinal centres dealing with



UT Khader

drugs are resorting to such practices and how they can be controlled," Khader said.

The meeting will include officials from the Drugs Control Department and will examine complaints involving expired medicines, incorrect labelling and high prices. Khader said the government was pursuing stronger inspection and enforcement in both the food and pharmaceutical sectors.

The minister also raised concerns about the growing sale of medicines through e-commerce platforms and the storage of drugs at premises that do not

hold the necessary licences. He said the government would consider introducing new guidelines governing online medicine sales.

The action followed complaints received from the public. Khader said, Drugs Control Department officials had taken action in response to such complaints and imposed fines on establishments found violating regulations. "There have been complaints about expired drugs, mislabelling and increased prices. We need to address these issues systematically," Khader said.

The state has also introduced barcodes to help consumers file and track complaints concerning medicines, he said.

Khader said the pricing of medicines largely falls under the Union government's jurisdiction and called for a more proactive approach from the Centre. He also pointed to cases in which medicines were sold without the mandatory Maxi-

mum Retail Price being clearly displayed, creating uncertainty for consumers.

He said there had also been instances in which hospitals charged considerably more for medicines than medical shops.

Amazon, whose facilities were among those inspected, said it was reviewing the findings of the inspection. "We are reviewing the observations from a recent inspection at our facilities in Bengaluru and will take necessary steps as required. We always extend our full cooperation to such inspections by various regulatory agencies," an Amazon spokesperson said.

"At Amazon, we have robust systems and controls designed to prevent products that do not meet applicable regulatory requirements from being listed on Amazon.in or entering our fulfilment centres. We continuously review and strengthen these controls," the e-commerce giant's spokesperson added

# TN CM Vijay lashes out at DMK over corruption, law and order

S Vijay Karthik

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**CHENNAI:** Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Monday lashed out at opposition Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) in the Assembly against alleged organised corruption, collection of party fund under the government-run Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation (TASMAC) shops, and law and order during its previous regimes.

Before leaving the assembly on September 3, Vijay had requested assembly Speaker JCD Prabhakar to ensure that DMK would not leave the House when he replies to the law and order situation on Monday.

As soon as the Speaker convened the assembly on Monday, requested Vijay to make his comments. In his over 45 minutes of speech in the assembly on Monday, Vijay cited Enforcement Directorate documents and alleged that the former chief minister M K Stalin and deputy chief minister Udhayanidhi Stalin were referred as the 'beneficiaries' under the collection of 'party funds'.

Displaying the ED documents during his fiery speech, Vijay said former DMK minister V Senthil Balaji and his brother Ashok Kumar were also involved in the corruption under the retail of liquors. "The great achievement of the DMK is the dishonest intention," he said citing the words described by the ED in its document.

Referring to the report of the Sarkaria Commission which had said that 2.5 per cent corruption in tenders during the term led by the then DMK President M Karunanidhi, Vijay said, "financial irregularities were done in an organised manner



(Top) Opposition leaders stage a protest during Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly session in Chennai on Monday and chief minister C Joseph Vijay addressing the assembly. PTI



and claimed it is a 'scientific corruption' that has taken place in the DMK regime.

Vijay also slammed the DMK that DMK MLAs oppose the TVK government when it speaks about corruption. "But they (DMK) never say that we never indulged in corruption," the chief minister said.

Responding to criticism by ruling Tamilaga Vettai Kazhagam (TVK), DMK led by its Leader of Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin resorted to protest by sitting in front of the Assembly Speaker asking his permission to speak. As he did not entertain, the leaders later staged a walk-out.

Udhayanidhi Stalin talking to reporters outside the Assembly hit out at the chief minister that he was delivering only 'punch dialogues' in the Assembly instead of the responding to the queries posted by him on Thursday.

"I too sat for 15 minutes in order to listen to his (CM) speech. He did not respond to any of the 15 queries I raised on Thursday (September 3). Everything was punch dialogues and he had prepared to deliver this speech during the last three days which were holidays (for the Assembly)," he said.

"After the completion of the 15 minutes, the chief minister

started to make accusations against the DMK and we asked the Speaker to allow us to respond. But before that he received a small piece of paper and after receiving that small paper, he did not allow us to speak. All these days, he (Speaker) allowed us to respond but today, he was supporting the ruling party," Stalin alleged.

Earlier, before commencing his speech, Vijay requested the Speaker that all members of the legislative assembly should maintain some political decency and decorum. "Do not make personal attacks on women. There is a river of abuse going across Tamil Nadu. People tend to make double meaning, triple meaning comments against women," Vijay said.

He recalled that the late former chief minister and AIADMK leader J Jayalalitha was also faced many issues inside the Assembly.

## DVAC F.I.R. NAMES KN NEHRU, KIN INVOLVED IN FINANCIAL SCAM

S Vijay Karthik

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**CHENNAI:** The First Information Report registered by the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption has named senior DMK leader and former minister K N Nehru, his brothers and senior government officials as accused in an alleged tender manipulation and bribery fraud case that amounted to proceeds of ₹ 1,020 crore.

As per the FIR accessed by HT, besides Nehru, K N Manivannan and Ravichandran (brothers of K N Nehru), former lawmaker (Madhavaram) S Sudarshanam, former lawmaker J J Ebenezer (R K Nagar) Kavi Prasad (close associate of K N Nehru) have been booked during the financial irregularities that has allegedly taken place between 2021 and 2025, when the DMK was in power.

Talking to reporters after the searches, K N Nehru said he and his team extended full cooperation to the officials throughout the search and said the DVAC did not find any significant evidence. K N Nehru is the current MLA from Tiruchirappalli West assembly constituency.

DMK chief and former chief minister M K Stalin had alleged that the searches were politically motivated and it was an attempt to intimidate the opposition.

However, TVK deputy general secretary and minister for energy resources and law C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar said the searches were a routine legal procedure.

# BRS claims manhandling by cops at state assembly

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**HYDERABAD:** The monsoon session of the Telangana state assembly began on Monday on a stormy note with Bharat Rashtra Samithi lawmakers being prevented by police from entering the House wearing black T-shirts with slogans written on them against the Congress government in the state. Before the session, BRS MLAs and MLCs gathered at the Telangana Martyrs' Memorial at Gun Park and took out a rally towards the assembly.

BRS working president and former minister K T Rama Rao alleged the Congress came to power by making "reckless and false promises" and had deceived various sections of society. As BRS leaders reached the assembly, police stopped them from entering the premises, citing absence of permission to enter the House wearing T-shirts with slogans. The objection led to a heated exchange between legislators and police and subsequently resulted in a scuffle.

Harish Rao allegedly used force to prevent them from entering the assembly. "KTR and former minister G Jagadish Reddy sustained injuries in



BRS working president KT Rama Rao, MLA T Harish Rao and other party leaders stage a protest outside the Telangana Legislative Assembly in Hyderabad on Monday. PTI

police highhandedness. But police did not allow us to take them to hospital," he said.

He further alleged that several BRS members were beaten and sustained bleeding injuries and claimed that women legislators were deliberately targeted. BRS MLA Sunitha Lakshma Reddy alleged police pulled her saree, while another MLA Sabita Indra Reddy accused police of dragging her by holding her hair. Harish Rao allegedly removed his shirt during the confrontation and threw it towards police.

DCP Shilpavalli defended the police action, saying BRS leaders were stopped at the assembly

gates in accordance with the directions of the speaker. "How can the MLAs enter the assembly without shirts?" she asked and rejected allegations that police pulled the sarees of women BRS leaders.

Meanwhile, the Congress hit back at the BRS for creating a drama outside the assembly. Party members also protested an alleged objectionable comment made by BRS MLC Tata Madhu against the speaker, during the protest. During the assembly, CM A Revanth Reddy said it was a "dark day" for Telangana and said it amounted to an insult to the state's four crore people.

## Rahul meets Satheesan



Congress MP Rahul Gandhi meets Kerala CM VD Satheesan at 10 Janpath, in New Delhi. "Had an engaging discussion on key issues concerning the development of Kerala, cooperative federalism, and matters of national importance," the CM wrote in a post on his X profile. @INCINDIA

# Keralam CM seeks NH-66 safety review after 8 from TN killed

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

**THIRUVANANTHAPURAM:** Kerala chief minister V D Satheesan on Monday wrote to Union Minister Nitin Gadkari seeking a safety review of national highways in the state after eight men from Tamil Nadu were killed in a road accident in Thrissur district.

The accident took place late on September 4 when a car carrying eight people from Dindigul district, who were students of an engineering college, rammed into the rear of a parked lorry on the highway at Panambikkunnu in Kaipamangalam, Thrissur.

In his letter, the CM urged the Union transport minister to impose strict restrictions on the unscientific and illegal parking of vehicles at national highway

construction sites, as well as on other heavy vehicles. Satheesan expressed hope that the circumstances leading to the accident would be thoroughly investigated, describing the loss of eight young lives as an "unbearable tragedy" for their families.

"I hope that the circumstances leading to this tragic accident will be thoroughly investigated. At the same time, this unfortunate incident raises serious concerns about the overall safety of the NH-66 corridor in Kerala, where extensive widening and construction works are underway," the CM said, adding "I would respectfully request you to direct the National Highways Authority of India to conduct an immediate, independent and comprehensive safety review of all stretches of NH-66 where construction is in progress."

## 'SECULAR FORCES, COMMUNISTS & CONG MUST UNITE TO FIGHT MODI'

Press Trust of India

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**HYDERABAD:** Telangana chief minister A Revanth Reddy on Monday said it is a necessity that the Congress, Communists and other secular forces should unite to fight against Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Speaking at a meeting organised in memory of CPI(M) leader Sarampalli Malla Reddy, who died recently, he alleged the Centre is removing anti-BJP voters names "deliberately, in a systematic manner" during the Special Intensive Revision of the electoral roll. Describing Modi as the "most dangerous person for the country," he claimed that "the victory of Communists lies in Modi's defeat" even if it meant Congress is in power.

While Communists took up struggles to address food, housing and other people's issues during the last several decades, Congress found solutions to them by making legislations, he said. He cited examples, including the MSP Act, NREGA, Food Security Act and 'Indiramma' housing scheme in Telangana.

"It is a historical necessity that Congress and Communist brothers, secular forces unite to fight against Modi," he said.

When the Congress and its leader Rahul Gandhi fought against the three black farm laws from the streets to the parliament, it had the cooperation of Communists, he said.

The BJP used ED, CBI and other central agencies to win elections, but "PM Modi discovered a new method -- to use SIR of Election Commission to remove anti-BJP voter names," he alleged. Claiming the poorest of the poor, SC and ST votes are anti-BJP, he said a conspiracy to remove one crore voter names is underway in Telangana.

## POLICE HUNT WB MAN AFTER BODIES OF WIFE, DAUGHTER FOUND

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**THIRUVANANTHAPURAM:** Police in Keralam have launched a manhunt for a West Bengal man who is suspected of having murdered his wife and daughter and dumped their bodies in sacks in a river in Palakkad district, an officer said on Monday.

The officer, attached to Pudur police station in Attappady, said the bodies of the woman (early 30s) and the girl (5) were found inside three sacks in Bhavani River near Cheerakadavu on Sunday. Cattle grazers spotted the sacks and alerted police.

"The bodies were found headless and at least four days old. One sack contained heads while other two had bodies. They were in advanced stages of decomposition. However, police identified them with help of local coconut plantation owners and officials," an officer said, adding "We learned that they lived near the plantation in Agali. He had been employed here for less than a month. We suspect him of the crime. He is currently missing."

# JJB in Keralam grants custody of 3 boys to police in murder case

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**THIRUVANANTHAPURAM:** The Alappuzha Juvenile Justice Board (JJB) on Monday, in a rare move, granted police custody of three boys, accused of murdering a 65-year-old man at his home, to facilitate the collection of evidence in the case.

Additional public prosecutor Manu Kallampally said the JJB's unprecedented order came in the murder case of Sivankutty Chettiyar in Karuvatta on August 15, allegedly by three boys aged between 16 and 17. The trio are accused of conspiring with a 13-year-old girl to murder Chettiyar and steal valuables, including gold, from his house.

"The JJ Act is silent on handing over minors in conflict with the law to police for collection of evidence. Since this is a case in which all the accused are minors, it is difficult for police to collect evidence and carry out the investigation without getting them in custody. So, the prosecution argued for the minors to be handed over to the

JJB LAID DOWN STRINGENT CONDITIONS, INCLUDING MAINTAINING SECRECY AND PREVENTING IDENTIFICATION OF THE MINORS

police for evidence collection under the provisions of the BNS. The JJ Board dismissed the defence's argument that there is no precedent for it," Kallampally told HT.

"It is the first such order by a JJ Board in Keralam and one of the rare decisions in India," he added.

The JJ Board has laid down stringent conditions, including maintaining secrecy and preventing identification of the minors.

"The boys have to be taken separately for evidence collection. Officers should be in civilian clothes. Police vehicles should not be used. District pro-

batinary officer has to be present. Time and date of evidence collection must not be publicised. They cannot be taken to a police station or kept in lock-up. These are among the conditions," said Kallampally.

The APP said that the case is unique because the crime took place at night inside a house without any eyewitnesses.

Crucial evidence including gloves worn by the accused at the time of the crime, a hair gel, a perfume bottle, etc. have to be collected. The house where the four accused conducted the conspiracy also has to be identified.

According to police, the 13-year-old girl planned the murder of her 65-year-old grandfather with her 17-year-old boyfriend and two others.

They planned to use the money and gold robbed from the house to buy iPhones and bikes. The victim was found to have been smothered to death with his hands and legs tied up.

Police will soon file a plea before the Alappuzha JJB to 'intervene' the 13-year-old girl in the case, the APP said.

## Singapore-bound flight lands in TN after tech glitch

**CHENNAI:** An Air India Express flight bound for Singapore from Tiruchirappalli on Monday made an unscheduled landing at Chennai airport after it developed a technical glitch mid-air, airport authorities said on Monday.

"All the 180 passengers including the crew are safe. Currently, the Aircraft is on Ground (AOG)," an official told HT on conditions of anonymity. Due to the incident there was no disruptions on aircraft operations at the Airport and it remained normal, he said.

## 26-yr-old man run over by TN min's personal vehicle

**CHENNAI:** A 26-year-old youth allegedly lost his life after the personal car of a Tamilaga Vettai Kazhagam (TVK) minister hit his two-wheeler on the arterial Grand Southern Trunk road near Chennai on the early hours of Monday, police said.

Due to the impact, the victim died on the spot. Iraiyanbu, 26, from Kattankulathur and was returning home after attending a temple festival. Police said the incident happened while he was trying to cross traffic signal in his scooter.

## University of Hyd receives artefacts of Sarojini Naidu

**HYDERABAD:** The University of Hyderabad on Monday said it received the artefacts of Sarojini Naidu at the restored Golden Threshold heritage building in Hyderabad, which was among the many cities the freedom fighter and poet lived in.

The event titled "Preserving the Poet's Legacy - Handing Over of Sarojini Naidu's Artefacts", was organised by the UoH, a release from the University said.

# Naidu tells TDP to strive hard for local polls' win

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

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**HYDERABAD:** Telugu Desam Party president and Andhra Pradesh chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Monday called upon party leaders and cadre to work with the single-minded objective of winning the upcoming local body elections in perfect coordination with the alliance partners - Jana Sena and Bharatiya Janata Party.

Addressing the inaugural session of the two-day TDP Leadership Conclave at the party's central office, Naidu cautioned the party functionaries against taking the local body elections non-seriously. The positive sentiment towards the coalition government should translate into electoral gains at the grassroots level, he said. "Local body elections should not be taken lightly. We must work with the goal of winning. There should be no gaps among party leaders and the alliance partners must remain united," Naidu said.

He directed party leaders to identify capable women leaders who could contest seats reserved for women in the local body elec-



TDP president and Andhra Pradesh chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu during the inaugural session of the two-day TDP Leadership Conclave at the party's central office on Monday. HT

tions. He also asked MLAs to set targets for development in their respective constituencies and identify 25 priority issues in every constituency.

Naidu said he was concentrating on ensuring victory in the next elections while also devoting time every day to the party in addition to governance. He said projects were being completed according to priority and efforts were being made to attract investments and create employment. The CM said all major irri-

gation projects, including the Polavaram project, would be completed within the stipulated deadlines and vowed to provide water to every acre in the state. He also asked party leaders to remain alert to the possible impact of El Niño and create awareness among farmers at the grassroots level.

He said the government was following a model of "political governance" while balancing development, welfare and good governance. He said he was

spending at least four days every month at the grassroots level and interacting with people through various programmes. Naidu stressed that strengthening the party's grassroots cadre was essential for electoral success. He said money alone could not guarantee victory in elections and urged public representatives to build an emotional connection with both the cadre and people. "Working alone will not produce results. If you convince the cadre and work with

them, the strength of public representatives will increase manifold," he said, adding that the party was encouraging people who performed well at the grassroots and had brought some of them into the politburo and state legislatures.

"Political party strength is important, but unity among the alliance partners is equally important," he said, asking alliance leaders to avoid disputes over photographs and flexi banners and instead work together at the grassroots.

Naidu also directed TDP leaders not to take the alleged "fake propaganda" of the YSR Congress Party lightly and to counter it firmly with facts. He accused the YSRCP of following a "hit, run and hide" approach and alleged that the opposition party was prepared to criticise any development initiative undertaken by the government.

Naidu urged party leaders to effectively counter what he described as distortions and misinformation. He asked them to remain active on social media platforms such as YouTube and Instagram and respond to opposition claims with facts.

# 5 held for chaining, parading Dalit youth on streets in Andhra

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**HYDERABAD:** The police in Andhra Pradesh's Vizianagaram district on Sunday arrested five people for allegedly chaining, assaulting, chaining and parading a 30-year-old Dalit man on the streets in full public view by over non-payment of money for a second-hand bike he had purchased from one of them, police officials said on Monday.

The incident happened in Bhogapuram town on Sunday. "We have arrested five persons - a bike mechanic Vennu Rajesh and his associates Lenka Sri-ram, Bommididi Venkata Rao alias Mahesh, Nammi Govind and Vennu Appa Rao," Vizianagaram SP A R Damodar said.

Bhogapuram police registered a case against all the five against under provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act and Section 109 (attempt to murder) of BNS, he said.

According to the SP, the vic-

tim had agreed to purchase a motorcycle from Vennu Mahesh, who runs a mechanic shed in Bhogapuram, for ₹11,500. He reportedly took the vehicle on August 11 for a trial run, saying he would pay the amount if he found the bike to be in good condition. However, he allegedly failed to make the payment and had been evading Mahesh since then.

"On the night of September 5, Mahesh and his associate Lenka Sri-ram allegedly caught the victim and confined him at the mechanic shed. The two reportedly assaulted him through the night and demanded that he pay the money," Damodar said.

When the victim allegedly failed to make the payment by Sunday, Mahesh, Sri-ram and three other friends allegedly tied his hands and neck with ropes and paraded him publicly along the streets, causing considerable commotion.

Photographs of the victim being paraded on roads went viral on social media on Sunday.

# 1951 to be as base year for Manipur NRC: Minister

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**IMPHAL:** Manipur home minister Govindas Konthoujam told the assembly on Monday that 1951 will be the base year for the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in the northeastern province, underlining that the state government was determined to push through the controversial exercise in the strife-torn region.

The Meiteis and Nagas want 1951 as the base year for NRC, when it was conducted for the first time in the state, but the Kuki-Zo communities oppose this. In the only other northeastern state where NRC was held in 2018, Assam, the base year was 1971, as per the Assam Accord. NRC is a sensitive issue in the state where the census was postponed by the Centre last week after sweeping protests that demanded NRC before population enumeration.

Govindas said that the state government will pursue the matter with the Centre in line with the resolution adopted last week by the assembly that said there should be no Census exercise before NRC in the state.

He made the remark while responding to a query raised by Congress lawmaker Keisham Meghachandra Singh regarding NRC. He added that the state government alone could not implement NRC without the approval of the Union government.

"The issue of NRC should not be taken lightly. The NRC has been implemented in Assam, but it still hasn't been made fully public. The matter is pending in court. The state government has already urged the cen-



Govindas Konthoujam

tral government to introduce the NRC in the state. The state government again urged the central government, following the assembly resolution on March 1, 2024, which reaffirmed its earlier resolution. Again on September 2, 2026, the House unanimously passed a resolution reaffirming its earlier decisions. We need to cautiously approach the Centre so that it doesn't fail like the Assam implementation," the home minister said.

Assam held its first NRC in 1951. The updation process began in 2014. The final report on updation of NRC for the state, which was supervised by the Supreme Court with the aim of weeding out illegal immigrants and got over in August 2019, had left out 1.9 million applicants. But that figure is debated, the list is yet to be ratified by the Registrar General of India and several petitions are pending in the apex court seeking partial or complete overhaul of the five-year-long exercise.

Responding to another question raised by Congress lawmaker Th. Lokeshwar Singh on illegal immigrants, the minister said that 24,475 undocumented immigrants were detected in the state so far. Out of these,

6,545 were detected in Kamjong district, 3,560 in Tengnoupal district and 14,370 in Chandel district.

"Of 24,475 illegal immigrants, 14,992 have returned to Myanmar, and 9,453 are still present in the border districts and have been kept in temporary shelters," he said, according to news agency PTI.

Some of them have been pushed back to Myanmar and some of them are taking shelter in border districts of Manipur, he said, adding that the process was carried out through diplomatic channels.

He said 14,992 people were pushed back into Myanmar. In Kamjong district, 5,378 out of 6,545 were pushed back, and the remaining 1,167 sheltered in camps opened by the government in community halls.

In Tengnoupal, only 14 out of 3,560 were pushed back, and the remaining 3,546 are being monitored by the government so they could not move to other Manipur districts.

In Chandel, 9,600 out of 14,370 illegal immigrants were pushed back and biometric records of 1,308 out of the remaining 4,770 were taken.

"Out of the 4,770 illegal immigrants in the district, biometrics of 1,308 have been taken," Konthoujam said, according to PTI.

On September 7, the Kuki-Zo Council (KZC) submitted a memorandum to Union home minister Amit Shah, saying that no Kuki-Zo organisation demanded NRC before census, urging the Centre to "not to proceed with any NRC exercise in Manipur on the basis of an unverified or historically unreliable 1951 baseline".

## NAGA LEGISLATORS BOYCOTT HOUSE SESSION OVER CIVILIAN KILLINGS

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**IMPHAL:** Naga MLAs of Manipur on Monday abstained from attending the ongoing session of the state assembly, in a protest against the killing of six members of their community, while demanding the government to take action against deputy chief minister Nemcha Kipgen.

President of Naga People's Front (NPF), Awangbou Newmai made the announcement to media in Imphal few hours before the sitting of the assembly session. He alleged that Thangboi Kipgen, the husband of the deputy CM, belonging to Kuki community, is the prime accused and responsible for the killing of six Naga civilians.

The six Nagas were allegedly abducted and killed after being held captive for nearly a month in Kangpokpi district allegedly by armed Kuki militants on May 13 following a twin ambush carried out on the same day at two different locations (Noney and Kangpokpi district).

The twin ambush had killed four individuals including 3 church leaders and one Naga man.

"The six Nagas were killed by chairman of Kuki national Front (Presidential) faction," Newmai alleged.

"We will not participate in the House until the it suspends or removes deputy chief minister Nemcha Kipgen from her post. Her husband is the prime accused," said Newmai.

## RAJ CHIEF JUSTICE TAKES CHARGE, CULLS ROSTER FOR SHARMA BENCH

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**JAIPUR/JODHPUR:** The newly appointed chief justice of the Rajasthan High Court Sanjay Kumar Agarwal on Monday restricted outgoing acting CJ justice Sanjeev Prakash Sharma's division bench to hearing appeals against orders of the Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT), hours after taking oath earlier in the day.

HT has seen the order, which also assigns work to three other benches of the Jaipur High Court. Till now, the division bench led by justice Sharma was entrusted with hearing a wide range of important cases at the Jaipur bench with Sharma functioning as master of the roster.

Justice Agarwal began his first day in office at the high court's principal seat in Jodhpur, where he sat on a division bench with justice Pushpendra Singh Bhati and heard cases.

A senior office-bearer of the Bar Association familiar with the matter said the change may be linked to the controversy regarding justice Sharma's tenure. The Supreme Court's justice Sandeep Mehta wrote three letters to CJI Surya Kant dated August 2, 10 and 17, seeking the immediate transfer of justice Sharma out of Rajasthan and the appointment of a chief justice from another state. Justice Mehta alleged that justice Sharma misused his powers as master of the roster, selectively shifted cases from other benches to his own court and passed orders that raised questions over integrity of the decision-making process.

In a fourth letter dated August 30, justice Mehta accused justice Sharma of interfering in an internal judicial enquiry, breaching confidentiality and abusing administrative powers.

(with inputs from PTI)

# Pb, Hry HC chief justice takes oath; Mann skips



Justice Ashwini Kumar Mishra

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**CHANDIGARH:** Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra was sworn in as the chief justice of the Punjab and Haryana High Court on Monday, even as Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann and his cabinet colleagues skipped the event over their opposition to the appointment.

Conventionally, the CMs of both stakeholder states — Punjab and Haryana — attend the swearing-in ceremony of the high court chief justice.

The oath of office was administered by Punjab Governor Gulab Chand Kataria at Punjab Lok Bhawan. The ceremony was attended by Haryana governor Ashim Kumar Ghosh, chief minister Nayab Singh Saini, sitting judges of the high court, and senior officials from both states.

Mann, whose administration strongly objected to the Centre notifying the appointment without awaiting state's feedback, left for New Delhi on Sunday, following an emergency cabinet meeting where it opposed the appointment, alleging it violated Para 6 of the Memorandum of Procedure.

The clause requires the state government's views to be obtained post-Supreme Court Collegium recommendation and prior to sending the proposal to the Prime Minister for executive decision.

Demanding the swearing-in be paused, the state said it received a letter from Union

minister of state for law Arjun Ram Meghwal on August 12 seeking consent. The collegium had recommended justice Mishra's name on August 6, but the notification was issued without waiting for Punjab's input.

Countering these claims, additional solicitor general Satya Pal Jain termed the state's stance "unfortunate and uncalled for," emphasising that the President made the appointment under Article 217(1) of the Constitution. Jain said the procedure was strictly followed, adding that state views are non-binding and do not grant "veto" power over judicial appointments.

Justice Mishra, 57, had been serving as acting chief justice since June 2. Appointed as an additional judge of the Allahabad HC in February 2014, he served there until his transfer to the Punjab and Haryana high court in July 2025.

AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal had previously alleged on August 9 that the Collegium overlooked seniority in

recommending Justice Mishra.

Punjab's opposition comes in the backdrop of an August 3 order passed by a bench led by Justice Mishra. The court directed the cash-strapped Punjab government to clear pending dearness allowance (DA) to employees within a fortnight while barring "unproductive expenditures", including major advertising campaigns, until dues were cleared. The state has challenged the ruling, which imposes an estimated ₹14,100 crore burden, in the Supreme Court. The appeal is yet to be listed for hearing.

Hours after his swearing-in, justice Mishra told lawyers that the court won't be "browbeaten by any tactics" and will defend "oath of the Constitution".

The remarks came during hearing of two applications filed by Punjab government employees and pensioners alleging that the high court order of August 3 that mandated release of up-to-date dearness allowance (DA) by the state government within 14 days, has not been complied with. Objecting to the statements of counsels of employees and pensioners, the state's counsel started addressing the court in a loud pitch. "This court would be governed by the rule of law and this institution will not be browbeaten by any kind of tactics. So, we will go strictly as per the law. We have taken the oath of the Constitution and we know how to preserve our oath and defend it," the chief justice said.

# Modi to unveil ₹35k-cr projects in Guj today

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Narendra Modi

**AHMEDABAD:** Prime Minister Narendra Modi will visit Vadodara and Navsari on Tuesday and inaugurate, dedicate and lay the foundation stones for development projects worth more than ₹35,200 crore in Gujarat, the Gujarat government said in a statement on Monday. The projects include works worth more than ₹32,606 crore of the central government and over ₹2,597 crore of the state government.

The "NaMo for Viksit Bharat" programme in Vadodara has drawn a strong public response.

Projects worth more than ₹30,766 crore under Indian Railways will be inaugurated or launched. These include three sections of the Western Dedicated Freight Corridor (WDFC), covering 326 km and built at a cost of ₹20,703 crore. The foundation stone will also be laid for third and fourth railway tracks between Vadodara and Ratlam over 259 km at a cost of ₹8,885 crore. Other railway projects involving gauge conversion and construction of second tracks

alongside existing lines will also be inaugurated.

PM Modi will flag off a new passenger train between Vadodara and Tanda Road and freight train services on the WDFC.

National Highway projects worth more than ₹1,840 crore will also be launched. These include works on NH-48 between Vadodara and Surat, including major bridges over the Tapi and Narmada rivers, six-laning of the Kamrej-Chalthan section and road improvement upgradation works on NH-53.

After the Vadodara programme, PM Modi will travel to Navsari, where he will inaugurate the BJP's newly built district office, Kamalam, and address party workers.

# NGO WITHDRAWS DEFAMATION SUIT AGAINST BBC OVER PM DOCUMENTARY

**NEW DELHI:** A Gujarat-based non-governmental organisation has withdrawn a defamation suit it filed against the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) three years ago in the Delhi High Court, accusing the broadcaster of defaming Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Indian judiciary by airing the documentary 'India: The Modi Question' in January 2023. It sought permission to file a fresh suit.

The documentary cited a previously unpublished United Kingdom foreign ministry report that questioned Modi's actions during the 2002 riots when he was the Gujarat chief minister. The government dismissed it as "propaganda" and a reflection of the "colonial mindset". The lawyer representing Justice on Trial, the NGO, told a bench of justice Tushar Rao Gedela on September 3 that he had instructions to withdraw the suit. "He states that he is under instructions to withdraw the...suit with liberty to file fresh suit for the same cause of action," the court said. The court dismissed the suit as withdrawn. **SHRUTI KAKKAR**

# Cong SC/ST MPs to meet Prez over U'khand 'purification' row

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**NEW DELHI:** Congress lawmakers from the scheduled caste and scheduled tribes (SC/ST) communities have decided to hand over a memorandum to President Droupadi Murmu, seeking her intervention in the "purification" incident in Uttarakhand's Haldwani following a rally addressed by party chief Mallikarjun Kharge, people aware of the matter said on Monday.

In total, 32 SC and ST MPs of the party held a meeting at the Congress's headquarters to form a joint strategy on the issue.

Congress's Lok Sabha MP from Telangana's Nagarkurnool, Mallu Ravi said, "We have sought time from President Murmu to submit a memorandum regarding the purification incident that has taken place after Kharge ji addressed a meeting. We will request her intervention in this matter. We want her to instruct the government to act of the issue that is illegal."

Chaired by Congress leader K Raju, the meeting also decided to launch political protests against the Haldwani incident.

Last week, senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi demanded that Prime Minister Narendra Modi order an FIR against those involved in the "shuddikaran" (purification) of the Ramilila

## Gandhi interviews party leaders for fresh Cong secretary posts

**NEW DELHI:** Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Monday interviewed numerous party leaders as the Congress plans to appoint several secretaries to boost the organisation.

According to two leaders aware of the process, Gandhi met aspirants in a few batches but he was "not happy" to see a large number of newly elected district presidents of the Congress to appear for the "interview", said a senior leader.

A senior leader said, "Gandhi felt that the district level

leaders should focus on their current responsibility—to strengthen the grassroots-level organisation—and not try to secure promotion by becoming secretaries of the party in Delhi."

At least 30 interviews were conducted in batches, a leader aware of the matter said.

In the coming days, more such meetings might be organised, the leader said. Gandhi asked the leaders about their view of the current issues including exam paper leak, purification controversy and the lack of jobs, he added. **HTC**



ground at Haldwani after Kharge, a Dalit, addressed a public meeting.

"Our demand is an FIR should be lodged at the earliest against those who performed Shuddikaran. The Prime Minister said he belongs to all castes. His party chief in Uttarakhand claimed Shuddikaran was the right thing to do. We want the PM to give order to file an FIR under the SC/ST act. This show the BJP and

RSS' mindset. They don't want a Dalit to become prosperous and live respectfully. We are not asking for anything impossible. According to the Constitution this is a crime. We are seeking justice for the Congress president. We are not asking anything more. It is a duty of the state government and the national government to ensure that Kharge ji gets justice in Uttarakhand," the Congress leader had said.

# Parl panel questions Centre over India's policy towards West Asia

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**NEW DELHI:** The government faced tough questions on its West Asia Policy during a meeting of the parliamentary consultative committee for external affairs chaired by external affairs minister S Jaishankar on Monday, people familiar with the matter said.

The meeting, held behind closed doors, focused on India's relations with West Asia, Jaishankar said in a social media post. It was also attended by minister of state for external affairs Pabitra Margherita, foreign secretary Vikram Misri and secretary (overseas Indian affairs) Sripriya Ranganathan.

Jaishankar faced questions from several of the MPs about India's policy towards the region, especially since military strikes by the US and Israel on



S Jaishankar

Iran in February that resulted in the death of Iranian Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and triggered a war, the people said on condition of anonymity.

The MPs questioned India's silence on the killing of the Iranian leader — the government refrained from formally condemning the killing of Khamenei — and criticised the perception that India was perceived as being in "Israel's corner", they said.

The MPs also expressed concern at the conflicts across West Asia and the situation that has prevailed since the terror attacks

by Hamas in October 2023 and the government's overall response, the people said.

The Makkah Joint Defence Agreement, signed by Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye on August 7, also figured in the discussions, with the MPs pointing to the open-ended nature of the pact and Bangladesh exploring the possibility of joining the arrangement, the people said.

Jaishankar said in his social media post that he highlighted India's "close ties with the Gulf & WANA [West Asia and North Africa] region, including our longstanding partnerships and cooperation in trade, investments, energy, maritime and people to people domains".

The people said Jaishankar had defended the government's approach towards West Asia by saying that India has to work along with all the key players in the region.

## J&K Int'l Film Festival begins



Jammu & Kashmir chief minister Omar Abdullah with directors and filmmakers during the opening ceremony of the International Film Festival J&K in Srinagar on Monday. Abdullah said that the film festival will give J&K exposure to world cinema.

PTI

# Gujarat may host 72nd National Film Awards

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**NEW DELHI:** The 72nd National Film Awards (NFA) will be held in Gujarat's Kevadia, a shift from the long tradition of the star-studded event taking place at Vigyan Bhawan in New Delhi, an official in the ministry of information and broadcasting (I&B) said.

To be sure, it isn't the first time that the NFAs are taking place outside of New Delhi. In 1970, the 17th edition took place in Chennai.

President Droupadi Murmu is scheduled to present the awards to the recipients at a ceremony on September 22.

The winners were announced on July 18. Article 370 was named "Best Feature Film", and Yami Gautam won "Best Actress in a Leading Role" it. Mammooty and

Kartik Aaryan shared the "Best Actor in a Leading Role" award for their performances in *Bramayugam* and *Chandu Champion*, respectively.

Rajkumar Periasamy won "Best Direction" for the Tamil-language war drama *Amaran*, while Ran-deep Hooda was named "Best Debut Director" for *Swatantrya Veer Savarkar*. *Kalki 2898 AD* won "Best Popular Film Providing Wholesome Entertainment", while *Captain Miller* was recognised as the "Best Feature Film Promoting National, Social and Environmental Values".

Veteran actor Sanjay Mishra won Best Supporting Actor for *Bhakshak*, while Sachana Namidass and Ropashree Varkady shared the Best Supporting Actress award for *Maharaja and Mithya*, respectively.

With inputs from agencies



# MP hooch tragedy toll rises to 20

Shruti Tomar and  
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**BHOPAL/SAGAR:** The death toll from the consumption of spurious liquor in Madhya Pradesh's Sagar district climbed to 20 on Monday, officials aware of the matter said, adding that 112 people have been hospitalised so far.

Police have registered an FIR against 30 individuals, including the liquor contractor, for culpable homicide not amounting to murder and have arrested 10 people.

The victims had consumed the spurious liquor on the intervening night of September 5 and 6. After consuming the liquor, the victims reported symptoms including nausea, vomiting, memory loss, high fever, and severe headaches.

District collector Pratibha Pal said, "Till morning, 13 people

have died. We are collecting information from all the hospitals and by Tuesday morning we will have actual numbers."

However, a senior health officer confirmed that seven more people died on Monday while undergoing treatment in Banda, Sagar and Bhopal and increased the death toll to 20.

A magisterial inquiry has been ordered into the matter, and the government has transferred the sub-divisional magistrate and the sub-divisional officer of police.

According to the FIR lodged at Banda police station, villager Anoop Singh Lodhi alleged that around eight people were selling liquor illegally in his village.

"He said that on September 4, he and his nephew Rajendra Lodhi visited Juhar Lodhi's shop, where they were told that a new cheaper brand had been supplied

**112 HAVE BEEN HOSPITALISED AND 30 HAVE BEEN BOOKED SO FAR FOR CULPABLE HOMICIDE NOT AMOUNTING TO MURDER**

by Barethi's licensed contractor Yashwant Singh, Manish Lodhi, and Banda resident Ashish Sahu. The liquor, transported by associates including Akash Rai, Rahim Khan, and others, was offered at ₹20 less than the market price," the FIR stated. "Rajendra purchased a quarter bottle for ₹70 and consumed it. His health deteriorated overnight, and despite being shifted from Banda to Sagar, he died during treatment."

According to investigating officer, the sale of Sagar Gold Red liquor, a countrymade liquor, is being cited as the primary cause in the case. Six shops have been sealed, and bottles of four brands have been seized for testing.

Investigators suspect the involvement of Lalitpur-based liquor mafia, Ravi Lakhera, who was released from custody just 15 days ago. "We are awaiting test reports before taking further action against traders. Local contractors and suppliers have been booked for selling cheap liquor, which led to mass consumption," said SP Anurag Sujania.

Meanwhile, Lalitpur Police on Monday refuted claims that the spurious liquor was supplied from Lalitpur. "No illicit liquor is being made from spirit or chemicals in Lalitpur and no such gang is active in the district at present...", the

press note from police stated.

Police said a gang led by Lakhera and Chandresh Lodhi of Sagar, along with five others, was arrested on May 4 and sent to jail. Action against them under the Gangster Act is underway. Lakhera holds several liquor licences in MP and has a criminal record in liquor cases, Lalitpur police said.

Of the 20 accused named in the Banda case, 19 are MP residents. The lone accused, Akash Rai, a Madavara resident, has been living in Banda for 10 years, police added.

Deputy chief minister Jagdish Deoda visited the affected villages.

Meanwhile, Congress state chief Jitu Patwari demanded an FIR against SP Sujania, alleging negligence. "The toll is much higher than government records. Similar tragedies occurred when Sujania was posted in Morena, and now again in Sagar," Patwari said.

## 5 CHAIN, PARADE DALIT MAN IN AP. ARRESTED: POLICE

**HYDERABAD:** Police in Andhra Pradesh's Vizianagaram district have arrested five persons for allegedly confining, assaulting, chaining and parading a 30-year-old Dalit man on the streets in full public view by over non-payment of money for a second-hand bike he had purchased from one of them, officers said on Monday.

The incident happened in Bhogapuram town on Sunday morning. The victim was identified as Ella Rajesh of Ramachandra Rajupeta area of the town. "We arrested five persons on Sunday. Bhogapuram police registered a case against all the five accused under provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act and Section 109 (attempt to murder) of Bharatiya Nyaya Samhita (BNS)," Vizianagaram superintendent of police AR Damodar said. **HTC**

# SC: Those who assault doctors can't roam free

Utkarsh Anand

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**NEW DELHI:** The Supreme Court on Monday said that people who assault doctors and hospital staff "do not deserve to roam on the streets even for a minute", forcing a Maharashtra corporator accused of attacking three municipal doctors in Thane to withdraw his plea after he allegedly assaulted and abused staff at a hospital in the district.

At least 17 people, mostly Sena workers, were booked in connection with the incident, which stemmed from a dispute over payment of the bill for treating five injured Dahi Handi participants.

"If something wrong was done by the hospital, they should have used the legal remedy. Taking the law into their hands cannot be tolerated, and the party will not shield such people," Shinde said, terming the incident extremely unfortunate. **HTC**

"This is their modus operandi. These people do not deserve to roam on the streets. Yesterday, again the same group of people assaulted doctors and hospital staff in Palghar," the bench said.

Rohatgi clarified that the accused in the Palghar incident were not the same set of people and said he wanted to "put a quietus to this here". "The writing on the wall is clear and therefore, I would want to withdraw," the senior lawyer said.

But the bench said that the court needed to send out a larger message against attacks on medical professionals. "A message needs to go...not only to these people but to everyone and as a deterrent...These people do not deserve to be out at all...Such people do not deserve to roam freely on the streets even for a minute," it said.

## SENA WORKER WHO ASSAULTED HOSPITAL STAFF SUSPENDED

**MUMBAI:** Deputy chief minister and Shiv Sena chief Eknath Shinde on Monday suspended party's Palghar unit chief Rahul Gharat, who will be expelled from the party, two days after he allegedly assaulted and abused staff at a hospital in the district.

At least 17 people, mostly Sena workers, were booked in connection with the incident, which stemmed from a dispute over payment of the bill for treating five injured Dahi Handi participants.

"If something wrong was done by the hospital, they should have used the legal remedy. Taking the law into their hands cannot be tolerated, and the party will not shield such people," Shinde said, terming the incident extremely unfortunate. **HTC**

The court issued notice on the Maharashtra government's appeal challenging the bail granted to Mhatre and three other accused. It also took note of reports about the fresh assault on doctors and hospital staff in Palghar and directed that the matter be listed on September 16.

With Rohatgi and other lawyers for Mhatre stating that they wished to withdraw the petitions, the Supreme Court allowed the withdrawal.

The exchange came days after the Supreme Court had already indicated that it was inclined to cancel Mhatre's bail over the alleged July 6 assault at the Shastri Nagar General Hospital in Dombivli. The Supreme Court had, however, said it would await a formal plea from the Maharashtra government seeking cancellation of bail.

# We're going back to the Moon, and want India by our side: Gor

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**MUMBAI:** A month after NASA invited the Indian Space Research Organisation (Isro) to join its Moon Base programme, US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor on Monday said the United States wants India "by its side" on the lunar surface.

"Make no mistake: we're going back to the Moon, and we want India by our side on the lunar surface," Gor said at the inaugural event of the ninth edition of the Bengaluru Space Exploration.

"The Moon may be our destination, but the engine of this journey is ground-level innovation, right here in our labs, startups, and commercial markets," the ambassador said.

Gor said India was a signatory to the Artemis Accords and that NASA had officially invited Isro to join the Moon Base programme. India joined the Artemis Accords in June 2023, becoming the 27th signatory to the US-led framework for cooperation in lunar and other space exploration.

The Moon Base programme, announced by NASA in March, envisages a phased approach combining robotic and human missions. The first phase, through 2029, will focus on robotic missions to explore the lunar South Pole, demonstrate technologies and lay the foundations for a sustained presence.

The second phase, from 2029 to 2032, will focus on building systems and infrastructure for a long-term presence, while the third phase will begin assembling a permanent lunar outpost where astronauts can live and work for extended periods.

Gor later met Isro chairman V Narayanan and said the two sides discussed taking space cooperation between the two countries further, including in human spaceflight. "Productive chat with @isro Chairman Dr. V. Narayanan on taking U.S.-India space cooperation even further, including in the human spaceflight program. @NASA's recent invitation to bring ISRO into its Moon Base program signals how far this partnership can go—to the Moon and beyond," Gor posted on X.



US envoy to India Sergio Gor in Bengaluru on Monday. **PTI**

## ISRO CHIEF SAYS WILL ADDRESS STAFF FEARS OVER PRIVATISATION

Snehal Fernandes

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**MUMBAI:** V Narayanan, chairman of the Indian Space Research Organisation (Isro), on Monday said the space agency is not privatised and it will address the concerns of 20,000 of its employees on privatisation of the space sector. He said that as per space sector reforms rolled out six years ago, Isro is supposed to handhold the private sector and grow the space ecosystem. Currently, Isro has around 450 space start-ups.

Narayanan, who is also the secretary of the Department of Space (DoS), was speaking to reporters on the sidelines of the inauguration of the 9th edition of the Bengaluru Space Expo 2026.

"Whenever a PSLV [Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle] or a GSLV [Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle] is lifting off, please don't think that everything is done by Isro or NSIL. Almost 80% of the budget is invested through Indian industries. Four hundred and fifty industries are working for us. That is the place we stand. So surely whatever my colleagues are having is a genuine concern. It is our responsibility to clarify," Narayanan said.

"If one or two people submit a letter, one cannot respond in writing. We are 20,000 employees. But we will address the employees," Narayanan added.

He added that Isro has to now work towards the country's requirement of around 50 launches per year that "will be accomplished by Indians in India".

# 12 pilgrims killed in Badaun accident

HT Correspondent

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**MEERUT:** At least 12 people have died and over 16 others were injured after a pickup vehicle carrying 32 devotees from Badaun overturned after hitting a road divider on the Eastern Peripheral Expressway in Uttar Pradesh's Baghat district early on Monday, police said.

Chief minister Yogi Adityanath expressed grief over the accident and directed officials to provide financial assistance to the families of the deceased and the injured.

The state government announced a compensation of ₹2 lakh each to the families of those killed while the injured will receive ₹50,000 each, an official said.

According to police, the inci-



Around 16 people are receiving medical treatment at the district hospital in Baghat. **PTI**

dent took place between Basi and Bada villages in the Khekra Kotwali area when the passengers were returning from a pilgrimage to Bagad Dham, a prominent pilgrimage site in Rajasthan's Hanumangarh district associated with Jaharveer Baba Goga Ji Maharaj. The victims were shifted to the district hospital, where six were declared dead.

# Why seek digital footprints of journalist, SC asks UP police

Abraham Thomas

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**NEW DELHI:** The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Ghaziabad police to explain why it is seeking digital footprints in a road-rage case against a Lucknow-based journalist who had flagged alleged donation theft at Ayodhya's Ram Temple.

A bench, headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, was hearing a petition filed by Abhishek Upadhyay, challenging an FIR lodged against him by Ghaziabad police in an alleged road-rage incident on August 18. The petitioner said the Ghaziabad police has requested the microblogging platform X to supply his digital footprints since June 2026.

"Let the Commissioner of Police, Ghaziabad clarify what kind of information is required from 'X' for the purpose of investigation into the road rage FIR or any other FIR registered against the petitioner," said the bench, also comprising justices Joy-malya Bagchi and V Mohana.

"In a road rage case, why will you require his digital footprints?" the bench asked the police counsel. "No such infor-



Abhishek Upadhyay

mation (pertaining to digital footprint) shall be brought in the public domain till the next date of hearing."

The Ghaziabad police, represented by Uttar Pradesh additional advocate general (AAG) Sharan Dev Singh Thakur, said there are two other cases being probed against Upadhyay that pertain to defamation complaints. Thakur also objected to the "wild allegations" levelled by Upadhyay in his petition alleging that the road-rage FIR was filed in retaliation to his coverage of alleged irregularities in the handling of donations at the Ayodhya temple.

"The only thing that concerns us is what should be the limits and parameters for the digital

footprints collected," said the bench, emphasising that a balance has to be struck between an accused's right to privacy and the rights of the victim and the investigating agency to thoroughly probe a matter.

Thakur said there is an eyewitness statement in the road-rage case, which is being investigated. He added that if nothing is found against the journalist, it would be closed.

Senior advocate Pradeep Rai, appearing for Upadhyay along with advocate Anoop Prakash Awasthi, said the court must lay down guidelines for the police in such cases.

Upadhyay has sought the quashing of the FIR or, in the alternative, that the investigation be transferred from the Uttar Pradesh Police to an independent agency such as CBI.

The petition states: "He apprehends that he may be arrested or subjected to physical harm by planted goons of the state machinery in the state of Uttar Pradesh before he can obtain effective judicial protection."

The court clarified that till next date, the interim protection from arrest granted to Upadhyay on August 25 will continue.

## ASI EXAMINES WELL IN RAZED U.P. MOSQUE

**MEERUT:** A debris-filled well unearthed at the Saharanpur Collectorate premises has prompted a historical assessment, with the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) and the Uttar Pradesh state Archaeology department officials inspecting the structure on Monday to determine its age, construction and possible historical significance, two days after a mosque at the site was demolished following a court order.

Manoj Kumar Yadav of the state archaeology department said the team's primary objective was to determine the well's antiquity and nature and correlate it with historical records.

"The structure is made using Lakhori bricks. The binding mortar used is a lime-surkhi mixture, and at a depth of three feet from the top surface, there is a thin layer of lime plaster," Yadav said.

According to Yadav, structures built using similar techniques are commonly found in the Upper and Middle Ganga Valley regions and generally date to the later medieval period (5th to the late 15th century).

He said further examination would be required to establish the precise age and significance of the well. **HTC**

## SC: NEED SPECIAL COURTS TO SPEED UP DISPOSAL OF RISING DRUG CASES

Abraham Thomas

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**NEW DELHI:** The Supreme Court on Monday said that considering the alarming increase of drug trafficking cases across the country, states and union territories must take steps to establish special courts for speedy disposal of these cases.

With 176 special courts set up so far for exclusive trial of cases under the Narcotics Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, the Centre told the court that based on an assessment carried out by the Narcotics Control Bureau based on interaction with states, union territories, and high courts, a total of 449 special NDPS courts will have to be set up across the country.

The bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said, "Owing to the current pendency of cases under the NDPS Act and the alarming increase in offences under the Act on pan-India basis, it is expedient and in the interest of justice that 449 exclusive courts be established."

ASG Aishwarya Bhati appearing for Central Gujarat court for a little nudge to the states and UTs which do not have a single exclusive NDPS court..

# Man kills wife, stores severed head in fridge

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**SILCHAR:** A 30-year-old cab driver in Guwahati was arrested for allegedly beheading his wife, who he suspected of having an affair, police said on Monday, adding that he kept her severed head in a refrigerator for five days until the body was recovered on Saturday night.

The accused, identified as Ramanuj Goswami from Dhubri's Gauripur, was produced before a court and sent to seven-day police custody, an officer said. He surrendered at the Hatigaon Police Station after initially fleeing the scene.

"He has confessed to the crime and said that it happened in a heated moment," said the Guwahati DCP Tabu Ram Pegu, adding that a sharp machete was used in the murder and it has been recovered.

"A blood-stained Dao (machete) has been recovered from the site and will be sent for forensic tests. We also recovered empty bottles of alcohol, and the accused said he was drunk when he killed his wife," Pegu added.

According to police, the incident happened on the morning of September 3, and the accused later left the house leaving the severed body behind. The matter

## COPS SEEK MAN FOR DECAPITATING WIFE, DAUGHTER

**THIRUVANANTHAPURAM:** Kerala Police have launched a manhunt for a West Bengal man suspected of having murdered his wife and daughter and dumped parts with their severed body parts in a river in Palakkad district, an officer said.

The officer, attached to the Pudur police station in Attappady, said, "The bodies of the woman in her early 30s and the girl (5) were found inside three sacks in the Bhavani River near Cheerakadavu on Sunday. They were found to be decapitated and at least four days old. One sack contained the heads of the two persons, while the two other sacks contained their bodies."

came to light after neighbours noticed a foul odour emanating from the couple's locked rented house in the Beltola area. Goswami and the victim, Riya Talukdar, 25 married in October last year and were living in the house owned by the accused's father.

Police said that during the search on Saturday, they recovered the victim's severed head, placed inside a black polythene bag, from the refrigerator.

Some of her severed fingers were also found.

# SC delivers reserved verdict in 2 yrs, breaks its 3-month limit

Utkarsh Anand

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**NEW DELHI:** The Supreme Court's prescription for judicial delay has run into an uncomfortable question of its own.

It took a bench in the top court more than two years to pronounce a judgment it had reserved on May 15, 2024, even as the same court, just three months ago, prescribed three months as the outer limit for the other constitutional courts to deliver reserved judgments.

A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and Manoj Misra on Monday refused to quash a CBI corruption and cheating case against pharmaceutical major Sanofi India Limited over alleged irregularities in the purchase of medicines by the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC) in Mysuru, involving an alleged loss of ₹3.53 lakh to the government.

In its 99-page judgment, the bench laid down the parameters for holding a corporate entity criminally liable, saying a company, though a juristic person, could be prosecuted without necessarily arraigning or identifying the natural person responsible for its affairs.

The court, however, said it was not enough merely to allege

## THE SUPREME COURT, JUST 3 MONTHS AGO, PRESCRIBED THREE MONTHS AS THE OUTER LIMIT FOR CONSTITUTIONAL COURTS TO DELIVER RESERVED JUDGMENTS

that a corporation committed an offence or possessed the requisite *mens rea* (mental state required to establish criminal liability). The allegations must prima facie disclose that some natural person or people acted on behalf of the corporation, that such action was connected with the offence in question and that the surrounding circumstances did not make the existence of *mens rea* "patently absurd or inherently improbable".

To be sure, the judgment in the Sanofi case was reserved on May 15, 2024, when senior advocate Sidharth Luthra appeared for Sanofi and the CBI was led by Additional Solicitor General SV Raju. The verdict was finally delivered only on Monday, taking the period between reservation and pronouncement to

more than two years.

The case itself had been pending before the Supreme Court for over seven years, with proceedings before the Bengaluru CBI court remaining stayed for that period following the top court's 2019 order.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on May 29 directed that high courts "shall endeavour" to pronounce a reasoned judgment within a maximum period of three months from the date of reservation. It also created an institutional mechanism to flag delays, requiring registrars general to place judgments pending beyond three months before the chief justice concerned, who could direct the bench to pronounce the judgment within two additional weeks.

The latest judgment thus comes against a backdrop in which the Supreme Court itself has repeatedly sought to impose discipline on the time taken by constitutional courts to conclude matters after hearings.

Monday's judgment is also not an isolated instance of prolonged reservation. Earlier this year, three other judgments were pronounced by different SC benches after having remained reserved for 11 months or more.

# Have fun with facts on Sundays

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



MORE IITs LIKELY TO OFFER B CYBER NEXT YEAR, DROP JEE MAINS ROUTE

Sanjay Maurya  
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**NEW DELHI:** Three to four more Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) are likely to offer the undergraduate B Cyber programme next year, potentially tripling the number of seats, even as the institutes plan to drop JEE Mains as an admission route for the course and introduce an aptitude test which would be followed by a hackathon-based selection process.

IIT Kanpur and IIT Madras launched the four-year programme this year, offering 40 and 50 seats respectively, but admitted only 52 students — 32 at IIT Kanpur and 20 at IIT Madras. “We want to do away with the JEE Mains from next year,” said IIT Kanpur professor Somitra Sanadhya, the programme proposer. The proposed aptitude test will assess problem-solving and basic computer science skills, including programming and networking.

Sanadhya said three to four more IITs are highly likely to join next year. The expansion comes amid concerns over a shortage of trained cybersecurity professionals. The curriculum combines cybersecurity, computer science, AI and systems, with projects and internships.

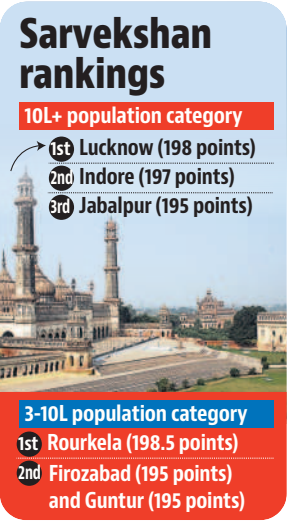
## Lucknow tops Swachh Vayu rankings, cuts PM10 by 46.4%

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**NEW DELHI:** Lucknow ranked first among National Clean Air Programme (NCAP) cities with a population of over one million in the fifth Swachh Vayu Sarvekshan rankings released by the Union Environment Ministry on Monday, recording a 46.4% reduction in PM10 levels in 2025-26 from the 2017-18 baseline. Rourkela topped the 300,000-one million category, while Kalinga Nagar ranked first among cities with populations below 300,000.

The rankings cover 130 NCAP cities and are based on the Swachh Vayu Sarvekshan Framework released in 2022-23. They assess measures to reduce road dust, solid waste, vehicular and industrial emissions, C&D waste and other emissions, besides Information, Education and Communication (IEC) activities. A compendium of best practices from NCAP cities was also released as part of Swachh Vayu Diwas 2026.

Lucknow (198 points) was followed by Indore (197) and Jabalpur (195). Delhi ranked joint 21st overall with 172 points. “The factors helping Lucknow included creating Miyawaki forests, using e-vehicles for waste collection



and transportation, road repair and black topping of nearly 560 kms of roads and bio-remediation of nearly 18.5 lakh metric tonnes of legacy waste,” said an official.

In the 300,000-one million category, Odisha’s Rourkela (198.5 points) ranked first, recording a 32.11% reduction in PM10 levels in 2025-26 compared with 2022-23. Firozabad (195) and Guntur (195) jointly ranked second. In the below-300,000 category, Odisha’s Kalinga Nagar (198.5 points)

ranked first, recording a 15.6% reduction in PM10 in 2025-26 from 2019-20.

The event was presided over by National Green Tribunal (NGT) chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava as chief guest, along with environment Secretary Tanmay Kumar and CAQM chairperson Rajesh Verma.

“The awardees have shown that clean air is not an aspiration but a practical goal that can be achieved with proper planning and ground level implementation” Shrivastava said, adding that clean air is a fundamental need rather than a luxury.

Since NCAP was launched in 2019, ₹16,425 crore in performance-linked grants has been released to the 130 cities. Around 108 cities have shown improvement in PM10 levels from the 2017-18 baseline, with 72 achieving a reduction of over 20% in PM10 concentration.

Separately, Union environment minister Bhupender Yadav held a dialogue with mayors and local body representatives from 63 NCR cities, who took a ‘Clean Air Pledge’. He emphasised a scientific and data-based approach to air pollution control, saying it must reach the grassroots. Yadav also said urban local bodies were the first responders in most cases.

## MAYA APPOINTS AKASH’S BROTHER TO KEY BSP POST

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**LUCKNOW:** Days after removing her nephew Akash Anand from the key organisational post of chief national coordinator for the third time, Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) national president Mayawati on Monday appointed Akash’s younger brother Ishan Anand as the chief sector coordinator for states other than Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand. Mayawati announced the appointment at a meeting of party leaders and office bearers in the state capital, people aware of the developments said.

The BSP’s organisational structure is divided into three sectors. Two sectors comprise other states while the third consists of Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand.

Ishan will attend meetings in these states and review organisational work, a BSP leader said. He will submit his report to his father Anand Kumar (Mayawati’s brother), who is the party’s national vice-president.

After the announcement, Akash Anand, who had earlier replaced “chief national coordinator” with “party worker, BSP” on his X handle, further amended his bio on the social media platform to “party supporter BSP”. Ishan mentioned his new status, chief sector coordinator, on his X handle.

## EOS-05 successfully reaches final orbit

Snehal Fernandes

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**MUMBAI:** India’s heaviest satellite launched on a GSLV, EOS-05, reached its final orbit on Monday evening, marking a key milestone for the Indian Space Research Organisation (Isro) after the failure of its previous GSLV Earth observation mission in 2021.

The 2,367-kg Earth Observation imaging satellite completed its third and final orbit-raising manoeuvre at 8.57 pm, with its Liquid Apogee Motor (LAM) engine firing for 1,247 seconds. The estimated orbit after the manoeuvre was 34,903 km x 35,884 km, Isro said on X.

“Third and final orbit maneuvering of EOS-05 spacecraft. The third and final orbit raising manoeuvre to increase the perigee (nearest to the earth) of EOS-05 completed successfully at 8:57 pm on September 07, 2026. The LAM (Liquid Apogee Motor) engine fired for 1247 seconds and the estimated orbit after manoeuvre is 34903 km x 35884 km. The satellite health is normal,” it posted.

EOS-05 was launched aboard the Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle (GSLV-F17) last week and placed in its intended sub-geosynchronous transfer orbit (GTO) on September 4. It

was then raised towards its final geostationary orbit using its onboard propulsion system.

The second orbit-raising manoeuvre was completed on September 6 evening. The LAM engine fired for 338.9 seconds, raising the estimated apogee — the point farthest from Earth — to 35,786 km.

The successful mission is significant for Isro after the GSLV-F10/EOS-03 mission failed in 2021. The onboard computer aborted the flight 307 seconds after launch.

At 51.7 metres, the GSLV-F17 is a three-stage rocket with a lift-off mass of about 420.5 tonnes. Its third stage uses a cryogenic engine and the vehicle has a payload capability of around 2,250 kg for the relevant orbit class.

EOS-05 will now continuously monitor India and nearby regions from about 36,000 km above Earth and provide important strategic data.

At a press conference after the launch, Isro chairman V Narayanan said the satellite’s life could exceed its assured seven-year lifespan.

“We will take it to the required orbit using the propulsion system of the satellite, and the assured lifetime of the satellite is seven years. I am confident it will work for more than nine years,” he said.

## KANPUR ENGINEER HELD IN MOSCOW, WIFE SEEKS HELP

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**KANPUR:** An Indian woman in Moscow has appealed to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, alleging that her husband was detained by Moscow police and could be pressured to join the Russian military. The Indian embassy in Russia has taken cognisance of the matter and said it was in touch with her and the local authorities and had sought consular access.

HT could not independently verify the authenticity of the video.

Sneha Chandan Gupta, who lives in Moscow with her husband Chandan Gupta and a 10-year-old son, claimed he was taken into custody on Sunday. Chandan works as an engineer with a Noida company and travelled to Moscow on a work visa.

Sneha said she was stranded in Moscow with her son and claimed her husband was detained and pressured to join the Russian army.

The embassy said on X: “We are in touch with her and with the local authorities. As per law enforcement authorities, this is a legal matter under examination by them. The embassy has sought consular access to the individual.”

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G

ARAVALLI DEADLINE

tions about ecosystem health, land-use change, hydrological systems, biodiversity, mining-induced vulnerability and landscape connectivity, it said.

The Supreme Court's insistence on a time-bound exercise comes against the backdrop of the controversy that erupted over the earlier definition of the Aravalli hills accepted by the top court in November 2025. An earlier committee constituted by the Union environment ministry had proposed that a landform in the Aravalli districts with an elevation of at least 100 metres from the local relief would qualify as an Aravalli hill, while two or more such hills within 500 metres of each other would constitute an Aravalli range.

The definition triggered criticism from environmentalists and other stakeholders, who warned that large portions of the ecologically fragile landscape could fall outside the regulatory ambit and become vulnerable to mining and other activities. The Supreme Court subsequently took suo motu cognisance of the controversy. On December 29, 2025, it kept its November judgment in abeyance and ordered a fresh examination by a high-powered expert panel.

The December order had questioned whether a height-based definition could adequately capture the ecological continuity of the Aravallis, including areas between hills and hillocks. It also questioned the scientific basis of a widely circulated claim that only 1,048 of 12,081 hills in Rajasthan met the 100-metre threshold, and whether a more exhaustive geological and scientific assessment was required.

The court has since kept a complete halt on mining in the Aravalli region pending the outcome of the fresh exercise and its consideration by the court.

While rejecting the extension on Monday, the bench stressed that the committee must hear all affected stakeholders. It specifically directed the panel to hear tribal communities in Rajasthan and Gujarat, besides the governments of Delhi, Rajasthan and Haryana, environmentalists, non-profit organisations, mining lease holders, project proponents, villagers, farmers and local communities whose livelihoods are linked to the Aravalli ecosystem.

The court said the eventual course of action must be based on scientific evidence and consistent with environmental protection and sustainable development. The committee's mandate, therefore, extends beyond drawing a technical boundary around the hills and ranges to examining the wider ecological and socio-economic character of the landscape.

The panel's interim assessment has described the Aravallis as a largely connected landscape with interlinked ecological, hydrological, biodiversity and socio-cultural values. It said the range comprises a network of small and large ridges and hill formations, many showing continuity or close spatial relationships. Even isolated hills and hillocks, it said, may have biodiversity, hydrological, ecological, aesthetic or cultural significance.

The committee has consequently suggested that the Aravallis be assessed alongside forests, protected areas, sacred sites, Orans and traditional pastures, wetlands, critical catchments, groundwater recharge zones and areas of archaeological significance, besides ecological corridors connecting with adjoining landscapes.

The panel is undertaking geospatial assessments and comparing its methodology with the Forest Survey of India (FSI)'s 2010 work and the conclusions of the earlier Centre-constituted committee. It has proposed validation by specialised agencies, including the National Remote Sensing Centre and the Indian Space Research Organisation, saying estimates of the area and number of hills could have significant ecological, regulatory and socio-economic consequences.

The five-member HPC comprises Kanchan Devi, former MoEFCC joint secretary Brij Mohan Singh Rathore, former Delhi University botany professor Ashok K Bhatnagar, former FSI director general Subhash Ashutosh and former Geological Survey of India director Rajendra Kumar Sharma. Jagdish Krishnaswamy, dean of the School of Environment and Sustainability at the Indian Institute for Human Settlements, and Laxmikant Sharma, professor at the Central University of Haryana, are special invitees.

The court has fixed December 2 for further consideration, by when the committee is expected to have begun submitting its issue-specific interim findings.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }  
DAC APPROVAL

49% to 74%, and improving ease of doing business.

The government aims to achieve defence manufacturing worth Rs 3 lakh crore by 2029-30 --- in 2025-26, India achieved defence production worth Rs 1.8 lakh crore.

The GBMPJ will provide effective jamming against radars of adversaries; the CBRN reconnaissance vehicles will be capable of detecting, identifying, monitoring and marking areas contaminated with CBRN agents; and Arudhra radars will replace the existing air route surveillance radars at various naval air stations and MGT, a warship propulsion system, will reduce dependency on foreign vendors, the defence ministry said.

High mobility vehicles will enhance operational capabilities, logistics support and mobility in challenging terrains, and self-propelled mechanical mine layers will be critical for fast and responsive minelaying in difficult terrains, it added.

The systems cleared for the army include trawl tanks and Sarvatra bridge system. These systems "will provide composite crossings to fighting formations during operations in varied terrains," the defence ministry said in a statement.

Approval was also accorded for installing the Defence Forces Secure Access Card system. It will replace existing paper-based identity cards, passes, and permits with an interoperable radio frequency identification-based smart card system.

DELHI COLLAPSE

The rescue operation concluded around 5.10pm on Monday and teams were withdrawn from the site, the Delhi Fire Service.

"My son had big dreams and I was working hard to make them come true...Everyone is telling us how bad the condition of the PG was. I wish my son had told me before. I would have never let him stay there," said Dewas resident Bhupendra Jai, whose son Arpit Jahaj was a 18-year-old student at ARSD college.

Driven by greed, building owner Hariram Bansal and his brother constructed four illegal floors in a nearly 50-year-old structure despite knowing that the building's foundation could give way under the additional load, the police FIR said.

The tragedy occurred around 1.30pm on Sunday when renovations were underway on the ground floor of the paying-guest accommodation, known as Hostel Daze. At the time, around were inside the building in a neighbourhood packed with matchbox buildings and cubbyholes offering little ventilation, dilapidated furniture, damp walls and blocked exit routes.

Seven people were pulled out dead from under the rubble. Five of them were students - Abhishek Kumar, 20, Yuvraj Soni, 20, Pawan Kumar, 17, Arpit Jahaj, 18, and Akshat Singh Yadav, 18.

The two others were Surinder Singh, 75, and Pawan Lal Kori, 30; both worked as labourers.

Those injured were Asgar Ali, 30, Neeraj Bawan, 19, Aditya Kumar, 19, Nitish Chib, 19 and Mohammad Ayan, 18, are students.

"[The building's] owners are Hari Bansal and his brother, who for the greed of rent had constructed four floors and some new construction was also going on due to which a lot of pressure was on the building's strength and due to that building's load bearing strength had crossed and today it collapsed," the FIR said.

The building - opposite Sri Venkateswara College on the west of Benito Juarez Marg - was one of dozens of PG accommodations in the congested resettlement colony teeming with restaurants, cafes, roadside eateries, stationery shops and grocery stores. The building had about 15 rooms, with two to three students in each. Rooms were let on a twin- and triple-sharing basis at about ₹12,000 to ₹15,000 a bed per month.

Police said the building was owned by Bansal, a resident of Gurugram, and registered an FIR under sections 105 (culpable homicide not amounting to murder), 290 (negligent conduct with respect to pulling down, repairing or constructing buildings), and 125 (act endangering life or personal safety of others) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) at the South Campus police station.

According to the FIR, seen by HT, the load-bearing capacity of the building was overwhelmed by additional floors and fresh construction, resulting in its collapse. Bansal and his brother were mentioned as the owners of the building.

"Despite knowing very well that the existing building's plinth could not handle a lot of weight and due to that the building could collapse and

claim people's lives, the building owner out of rent greed deliberately constructed the building to upper floors...by doing so the owner has caused loss to life and property. Hence, as per to the PCR call, entire circumstances and medico-legal certificates (MLCs of dead and injured), prima facie a cognizable offence under sections 105, 209 and 125(a) is found to have happened," said the FIR, written mostly in Hindi.

The FIR No-153/2026 was registered on Sunday night on the complaint of assistant sub-inspector Praful Toppo. "Local enquiry revealed that HostelDaze PG was running in the building comprising ground plus four upper floors...many students and people lived inside the building and some people trapped due to the sudden collapse of the building," the FIR added.

Deputy commissioner of police (southwest) Amit Goel said Bansal was arrested from Bhiwadi, where he had allegedly fled on Sunday. "During examination, it was found that the property is in Urmila's name and was being managed and run by Hariram and Mahesh. Electricity connections of two floors are in Hariram's name. He is a retired Sergeant from the Indian Air Force. Mahesh is running a hardware and paint shop," Goel said.

A senior investigator said the probe showed the building did not have a beam to support the floors, the roof or any pillar, and that the owner had two shops on the ground floor and a basement adjacent to the shops where construction work was underway, leading to the collapse.

"He had planned to renovate the two shops and turn them into one. There was a wall in the middle which they had demolished which we suspect weakened the building. Water had also flooded the basement and he had planned to fill it with cement as a part of the renovation, therefore, there was also cement inside. All of this culminated in the weakening of the base which led to the collapse," the officer said, requesting anonymity.

Another officer said the building was around 50-years-old and initially had two floors. "The construction of this building was not flagged to police before it collapsed," added the second officer. Police said Hariram and his family own at least two more properties in the neighbourhood.

The accident was the latest in a string of building failures and fires in Delhi over the past year that have raised questions about regulation, enforcement and the role of senior officials and ministers. On June 3, a fire at a bed-and-breakfast in Hauz Rani killed at least 23 people, including foreign nationals. Four days earlier, the collapse of an illegal building in adjacent Saidulajab killed six. In May, a fire tore through a residential building in Vivek Vihar, killing nine. On March 18, a blaze in a Palam Vihar building killed nine.

In the face of mounting criticism, MCD suspended deputy commissioner (DC) of the south zone, Rakesh Kumar, superintending engineer Ranvir Singh, executive engineer (building) Lalit Kumar Goel, assistant engineer (building) Sunil Chauhan, and junior engineer Ashish Kumar. The move came after chief minister Rekha Gupta's order.

"The Delhi government, in coordination with MCD, is working towards introducing a policy under which every building used for public activities, whether a PG, nursing home, school or any other institution, would be required to undergo periodic structural audits and obtain building safety certification. No building would be allowed to conduct public activities without ensuring its safety," said the CM.

Lieutenant governor (LG) Taranjit Singh Sandhu directed urban development minister Ashish Sood to lead a committee with concerned senior officials to review institutional PG guidelines, explore alternative student accommodation and assess the feasibility of using unutilised DDA housing stock for student accommodation.

This is only the second time in 18 years that an IAS level officer (deputy commissioner) level officer has been suspended by the civic body in the aftermath of a building collapse. An MCD official said that Kumar was a 2015-batch officer promoted via the Bihar Public Service Commission, and was currently serving on deputation.

"All 12 zonal deputy commissioners in MCD are currently from other services serving on deputation. The maximum punishment in their case can be repatriation and recommendation of disciplinary action to the parent cadre," the official added.

2.9mn hit by floods across 13 Bihar distts; CM reviews relief ops

Subhash Pathak

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**PATNA:** Around 2.9 million people have been affected by floods in Bihar as overflowing rivers inundated large swathes in 13 districts, according to the state's disaster management department (DMD).

Chief minister Samrat Choudhary, accompanied by deputy chief minister and WRD minister Vijay Kumar Choudhary and deputy CM Bijendra Prasad Yadav, on Monday inspecting the relief operations in Vaishali and Saran areas.

Officials said 190 community kitchens are being run in various flood-hit districts, while 1,429 boats have been deployed for relief and rescue operations.

Choudhary, later in a social media post, said, "I stand with the people through every challenge and at every step. I visited flood-affected areas of Vaishali and Saran and inspected relief camps in Hajipur and Sonpur,



People move to safer places on makeshift boats in Patna's Bind Toli area.

where I interacted with residents, reviewed arrangements, served food and shared a meal with them."

Financial assistance was provided to the disaster victims, while affected farmers will receive due compensation for crop losses, he said.

Authorities have already sounded an alert in downstream areas of the Ganga after the river touched its highest flood mark at Gandhi Ghat and Hathidah in Patna.



MP IAS officer transferred for 4th time

**BHOPAL:** Madhya Pradesh IAS officer Neha Marvya was transferred for the fourth time this year, less than two months after taking charge as Tribal Area Development Project director. She told the IAS Association: "By the time I understand the charge, I get removed." Marvya alleged subordinates threatened to get her transferred after she issued notices seeking explanations.

She has now been appointed managing director of the MP ST Finance and Development Corporation.

Odisha notifies rules for settlement of Jagannath land

**BHUBANESWAR:** The Odisha cabinet on Monday approved new rules to bring the management and settlement of land belonging to the 12th century Jagannath Temple under a fully digital and more tightly monitored system, with safeguards to prevent encroachment and fraudulent claims.

Kanpur woman held for hiring two to kill her father-in-law

**KANPUR:** A 30-year-old woman was detained by Kanpur police on Monday for allegedly hiring two people, including her domestic help, to kill her 63-year-old father-in-law. The man was found dead at his home with 26 stab wounds on September 5. The two accused were arrested, police said.

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# OPINION

The  
**Hindustan Times**  
ESTABLISHED IN 1924

{ OUR TAKE }

## Preparing for an extreme 2027

India's mitigation efforts on rainfall need a multi-dimensional, long-term approach

India is now in the last three weeks of its four-month-long monsoon season. A weak monsoon was expected this year, and so far, rainfall is 14% below its Long Period Average (LPA), confirming these expectations. It is unlikely that the overall rainfall performance will improve significantly in the rest of the month. The IMD, in fact, expects rainfall to be weak.

What does all this mean? India will have a deficit of more than 10% in monsoon rainfall for the first time since 2015, to be precise. This will have consequences for agricultural production, reservoir levels, and, in some cases, even drinking water availability. Because the El Niño conditions have only strengthened — scientists expect it to be one of the strongest in a long time — the monsoon rainfall deficiency will hurt more going forward and last until at least the March-May season next year. The spring and summer of 2027 will likely be hotter than 2024. Mitigation efforts, both for the food and non-food fallout of low rainfall, must begin in earnest. This will require collaboration between central and state governments.

To be sure, headline monsoon numbers only tell us a part of the rainfall story in India. The recent situation in Bihar, which officially has a 35% monsoon rainfall deficit this season, is a good example. Large parts of the state, including the landmass south of the Ganga, are facing a severe flood situation. Traditionally, the flooding problem in the state is confined to its northern half, where rivers originating in Nepal and higher Himalayan regions create the problem. This time it's the rainfed rivers originating in central India that have led to large-scale destruction of crops and loss of property.

This is a point *HT* has highlighted repeatedly in its data analysis of monsoon rainfall in India. Even when headline numbers suggest normal rainfall, its temporal, geographical and intensity variation can be very different. These variations can have a large role in making rains a useful or harmful prospect for dependent activities. Such variation, data shows again, has been increasing over time. This is exactly why India's mitigation efforts vis-à-vis rainfall need to evolve in a multiverse rather than tracking just the cumulative monsoon rainfall. This will require scientific, holistic and vanguardist planning. It will also require long-term investment. Unfortunately, politics is becoming a prisoner of short-term relief. It's a vicious cycle which needs to be stopped.

## A resurgence of the Right in Germany

Nationalism is representation, proposed Catherine Frost, a noted scholar of nationalism, who saw it as a system people use to morally represent or define themselves. So, what does the emphatic performance in Saxony-Anhalt, with around 44% of the vote for the Alternative für Deutschland (AfD), an extreme Right-wing party with nationalism as its plank, say about Germany? Maybe it's too early to gauge. But a vote-share more than double the ruling Christian Democratic Union (CDU)'s tally is a significant political event. For the first time since 1945, a party that German intelligence agencies labelled Right-wing extremist could govern a German province. As if the AfD's ethnic rhetoric on immigration wasn't dangerous enough, the CDU's collapse to 17.2% vote-share shows electors have stopped believing in the centrist party's ability to deliver civic guarantees to citizens.

For India, there should be more than academic interest in this development. Germany is India's largest trading partner in the EU and a magnet for Indian students, engineers, and tech workers. The AfD has been explicitly targeting Indians in its immigration rhetoric, alongside Muslims and Ukrainians. If the party continues to grow in strength and eventually influences federal policy to make Germany look inward on visas and skilled migration, it will hurt India. As the largest democracy in the world, India should also be concerned about the increasingly lopsided balance between nationalist rhetoric and pluralism in the European continent, which has shown that relative social harmony and economic prosperity are no firewall against immigrant-blaming, religious rabble-rousing instincts. To be sure, this result could be just a temporary protest against Merz's coalition rather than a bellwether for a socio-political realignment. The picture will become clearer as other German provinces vote in the coming weeks.

## Muddied legal waters of the Indus Treaty

India now needs to make its public case plainly. It should explain why parallel proceedings violate the Indus Waters Treaty and how it will protect its legitimate hydropower rights

On August 31, 2026, the Court of Arbitration in The Hague held that the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT) remained fully in force despite New Delhi's decision to hold it in abeyance. It also issued a limited interim order on Ratle. The order does not halt the project. It restricts concreting above specified levels in parts of the dam wall and power intake until 90 days after the Neutral Expert's final decision and requires reports on the construction schedule. The Court declined two other measures sought by Pakistan. India did not take part in the proceedings. The ministry of external affairs rejected the Court's award and interim order, saying the Court had neither legal existence nor jurisdiction to rule on India's position. The more fundamental issue is whether this Court was validly constituted at all. Its authority now matters as much as the technical

dispute over the dam.

India's objection goes back to the Court's creation. New Delhi opposed it before any ruling was issued. Pakistan first requested a Neutral Expert, withdrew that request, and then described its objections as arbitral disputes in August 2016. India sought a Neutral Expert that October. That process now covers both Ratle and Kishenganga. The World Bank passed both appointment processes because it saw a risk of contradictory outcomes. It later completed both appointments in 2022, despite acknowledging practical and legal difficulties. A Court whose authority India contests has linked work at Ratle to the outcome of a separate Neutral Expert process, allowing two forums to shape the same project at the same time.

India's argument is that the IWT was not designed to permit two overlapping tracks for the same kind of technical controversy. Article IX of the IWT first sends disagreements to the Permanent Indus Commission. Technical differences go to a Neutral Expert. Disputes go to arbitration. India also relies on paragraph 6, which suspends the steps leading to arbitration while a difference is before the expert. On this reading, Pakistan cannot convert an engineering objection into an arbitral case merely by changing the label. The

choice of forum matters. A Neutral Expert deals with defined technical questions. Arbitration can open wider issues of treaty interpretation and procedure. An Indian project can then remain tied up in proceedings for much longer.

The Court rejected India's objections in 2023. A tribunal may examine its own jurisdiction, but that power does not enlarge the consent given under

Article IX. A later award cannot erase India's original objection. A State's absence does not settle jurisdiction either way. The US contested jurisdiction in the Nicaragua case and later withdrew from the merits, but the International Court of Justice continued. China refused to accept or participate in the South China Sea arbitration, and that tribunal also continued. In the Aegean Sea Continental Shelf case, Turkey did not appear at the jurisdictional stage, yet the International Court of Justice still examined consent and found that it had no jurisdiction. India stayed away because it maintains that Article IX did not authorise this Court.

A harder question is what abeyance means in practice. Article XII(4) says the IWT remains in force until terminated by a duly ratified treaty between the two governments. India does not claim formal termination. The issue for New Delhi is how this system



Syed Akbaruddin



India has continued to protect civilian water needs while reserving its right to respond to the conduct of the Pakistani State.

SHUTTERSTOCK

of cooperation can function in the radically altered security environment of 2026. The IWT operates through notices, drawings, inspection visits, data tables and meetings. These procedures require a minimum of reciprocity and good faith. Before placing the IWT in abeyance, India had invoked Article XII(3) and sought a negotiated modification.

Through wars, terrorist attacks and prolonged hostility, India has continued to protect civilian water needs while reserving its right to respond to the conduct of the Pakistani State. The IWT's water allocation rules and its machinery for daily cooperation are not the same thing. By treating every obligation as fully operative, the Award preserves the text while saying too little about the security and political conditions needed to make its procedures work. The preamble's references to goodwill, friendship and a cooperative spirit record the assumptions on which this demanding regime was built.

Ratle shows the practical cost. The IWT permits India limited run-of-river hydropower on the Western Rivers,

subject to design rules. That right can be worn down without being formally denied. Repeated objections, parallel proceedings, delayed decisions and interim restraints can leave India with a right that exists on paper but is difficult to use on the ground.

India's rejection must be backed by a clear public narrative explaining why treaty cooperation cannot be separated from the security conditions that make it possible. New Delhi should set out its objections to parallel proceedings and how it will protect its legitimate hydropower rights. It should also restate that normal cooperation can resume only when Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures support for cross-border terrorism. An order can mark a level in concrete. It cannot answer India's objection to the Court's creation or restore the reciprocity the IWT requires.

*Syed Akbaruddin served as India's permanent representative to the United Nations in New York and is currently dean, Kautilya School of Public Policy. The views expressed are personal*

## Privatising missile sector to preserve autonomy

India's decision to open the conventional missile sector to private industry marks an important inflection point in the evolution of the country's defence-industrial strategy. Defence minister Rajnath Singh recently approved the transfer of Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO)-developed technologies covering conventional missile systems to eligible Indian defence companies, both public and private, for domestic production.

The significance of the decision extends well beyond technology transfer. It represents an attempt to move India's missile ecosystem from a predominantly State-led model of development and nominated production towards a more competitive industrial structure in which multiple companies can develop manufacturing capacity, integrate complete weapon systems and compete for orders.

This is a logical extension of measures undertaken earlier in 2026 to dilute Bharat Dynamics Limited's (BDL) near-monopoly in tactical missiles and create a wider network of development-cum-production partnerships. Private companies can now compete for technology transfer, qualify as Development-cum-Production Partners (DCPPs), and emerge as full-system integrators rather than remaining confined to supplying components or subsystems.

The systems potentially covered are substantial: surface-to-air missiles, air-to-air weapons such as Astra, anti-radiation missiles including the Rudram family, anti-ship and anti-tank missiles, land-attack cruise missiles and quasi-ballistic tactical systems such as Pralay. Longer-range conventional strike systems, including land-attack cruise missiles in the roughly 1,000-1,500 km category, are also being considered for greater private-sector participation. Nuclear-capable strategic systems, particularly the principal Agni series, remain subject to much tighter controls.

India wants to build a missile industrial base rather than merely produce missiles. The immediate rationale is familiar: Atmanirbhar Bharat, import substitution and greater domestic capacity. But the strategic logic is deeper. Modern warfare has demonstrated that precision weapons are no longer niche capabilities reserved for limited contingencies. They are increasingly central to sustained campaigns in which stocks can be rapidly depleted and industrial capacity becomes a determinant of military effectiveness.

For India, this has an obvious China dimension. A prolonged conflict would test not merely the quality of individual weapons but the country's ability to replenish them at scale. A missile ecosystem dependent on a limited number of production lines cannot provide the resilience that a major military power requires.

The old model, in which the State developed a weapon and nominated a public-sector enterprise for production, was useful in building an initial industrial base. But it also created structural limitations. Limited competition reduced pressure on manufacturers to improve productivity, lower costs, and expand capacity. The new model seeks to correct this by separating technological ownership from manufacturing monopoly. This is also consistent with the direction of the draft Defence Acquisition Procedure 2026, which seeks to establish a level playing field between public and private manufacturers.

Expanding beyond BDL can create redundancy, accelerate production and strengthen wartime resilience. Private firms can also move up the value chain from components and sub-systems to full-system integration involving guidance, propulsion, seekers, software and testing. This will deepen supply chains, integrate MSMEs and raise indigenous value addition. A

broader industrial base can simultaneously support India's growing defence-export ambitions by enabling scale, competitive pricing and reliable supply. The objective, therefore, is the creation of a resilient ecosystem capable of designing, producing, upgrading and exporting sophisticated missile systems.

Missiles combine some of the most demanding areas of defence engineering: propulsion, seekers, guidance, control systems, electronics, software and materials. A company capable of manufacturing a missile subsystem is not automatically capable of integrating a complete weapon system to the reliability standards required by the armed forces.

Companies will have to navigate defence manufacturing licences, explosives-related approvals, quality certification, security requirements and specialised testing infrastructure. Developing the necessary workforce and facilities will require substantial capital and patience.

Greater private participation should not become a contest between private companies and institutions such as DRDO, BDL and Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL). The objective should instead be to create an ecosystem in which DRDO focuses increasingly on advanced research and next-generation technologies while industry takes greater responsibility for production, integration and lifecycle support.

Legacy arrangements do not disappear merely because policy changes. The government will, therefore, need to ensure that competition is genuine rather than simply adding private firms to an otherwise unchanged procurement structure.

The greatest challenge may ultimately be one of scale. Private companies will invest in dedicated production facilities only if they have reasonable confidence about future orders. At the same time, the government cannot guarantee every company a sufficient production run merely to protect private investment. India will, therefore, need a procurement architecture that provides predictable demand while preserving genuine competition. The same principle applies to advanced systems. Conventional long-range and eventually hypersonic weapons will require substantially greater technological maturity and industrial capability. The distinction between conventional and strategic systems will also remain important: Nuclear-related missile programmes will continue to operate under a far more restrictive security framework.

Technology transfer must translate into absorbed technology. Competition must translate into lower costs and faster production. Private investment must translate into actual capacity. And increased capacity must ultimately translate into military resilience.

India is moving away from an industrial model in which the State was simultaneously the principal developer, customer and manufacturer, towards one in which the State acts as technology provider, regulator and customer while a wider industrial base undertakes production. That is a significant structural change. The objective should be to create a defence-industrial architecture capable of surviving the pressures of modern warfare, where technological advantage matters, but so do production volumes, supply-chain resilience, cost, innovation and the ability to replace losses quickly.

India's strategic autonomy will ultimately depend on whether it can design and manufacture sophisticated missiles in sufficient numbers and sustain their production under wartime conditions. The opening of the conventional missile sector to private industry is an important step in that direction.

*Harsh V Pant is vice-president, ORF. The views expressed are personal*

{ SERGIO GOR } AMBASSADOR OF THE US TO INDIA



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On India-US partnership in space sector



## How India can bag its next hockey World Cup

The Indian men's hockey team has won successive bronze medals at the last two Olympics — and that's definitely a matter of pride. But we failed to replicate that performance at the recently concluded World Cup. What matters now is that each player understands the value of these big tournaments, which come only once every four years. At the World Cup, we knew we had to beat Argentina by a margin of two goals to reach the semis. Instead, we conceded in just 40 seconds. We'll have to work on these things.

Modern hockey demands complete focus on every second spent on the pitch, and its demands have changed with every passing step. So, two or three players might win you a match, but to win a tournament, all 18 need the same mindset and the same aim. The players receive proper training and full support from Hockey India (HI) and the government. They need to recognise and value that.

Today, there's very little separating the world's top six or seven teams. It comes down to how much effort you put in on the day — and we need to be a step ahead of them. In some areas, like defence, some teams are already two steps ahead of us.

In modern hockey, the forward line serves as the first line of defence. From there, we must maintain our position and structure for all 60 minutes — from the first pushback to the final whistle. We also need disciplined hockey. We can't win with 10 players. We also need to communicate better.

Today's hockey is all about touch play. Because the game moves so fast, you can only hold the ball for a few seconds — the rest of the time, you're running back and forth, which is why communication is so critical. You don't have time to lift your head and look for your teammate; the connection has to happen through eye contact — like pressing a Bluetooth button to get connected.

We spend so much time in national camps, away from home, preparing for four years — but small errors like these cost us these tournaments. We have a good team, but we can't be 100% in the first quarter and only 70-80% in the second.

Our target is to win the Asian Games now. After that, we'll have two years to prepare for the 2028 LA Olympics. We should focus more on video analysis to identify where we're going wrong, and train accordingly. The harder we train, the easier matches will become. That mindset should start

today if we want to upgrade our medal from bronze to gold.

I've been thoroughly impressed by the women's team's performance. The team fought hard at the World Cup, whether they won, lost or drew. Their discipline, ball movement, fearlessness and commitment were commendable — even under heavy physical challenge from opponents, they kept fighting back.

This showed that the players had studied their opponents well — their strengths, weaknesses, penalty-corner tactics and defensive patterns. The lesson here is that doing your homework matters.

If the women's team takes care of the small things, matching the best in the world won't be difficult. They should treat hockey like a school subject — English or Hindi — analysing their strengths as well as areas for improvement to sharpen their basics. Their basics are already strong, as the World Cup showed. They need to improve slightly on defence and be more proactive to consistently match the best.

If we fix these small things, I don't think anyone can touch us. The women's team has shown remarkable improvement over the last decade, but we need to work harder to reach the top.

Building an India A team as a backup is essential — having upcoming players train alongside the seniors will create healthy competition. If someone is not performing in the senior group, that player can be demoted to India A and vice versa. In addition, the India A players should get more exposure tours. We also need to strengthen our domestic structure. The transition from domestic to international hockey takes too long to adapt to, because the domestic game is far slower.

In domestic hockey, if you stop the ball, you have all the time in the world to make a good pass, with no pressure. In international hockey, teams constantly close you down, leaving you no time to even lift your head. How you handle that pressure reveals your true strength.

Hopefully, the World Cup was a valuable lesson for both teams as they prepare for the Asian Games. We are strong tactically. We've good coaching staff. Some ingredients of a win are already there. We need to now add the others that are needed.

*Sardar Singh is a former India captain and a Khel Ratna awardee. The views expressed are personal*

WORLD



**Russia open to three-way talks with Ukraine, US**  
**MOSCOW:** Russia does not rule out fresh, three-way talks with Washington and Kyiv on the Ukraine war, the Kremlin said on Monday, after a visit to Moscow and Kyiv by US negotiators Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner.

AFP

**\$320mn stolen in crypto hack, claims Bitcoin network**  
**WASHINGTON:** A Bitcoin-linked blockchain used by several crypto exchanges has been hacked for \$320 million. Liquid Network, which develops a blockchain designed for faster transactions, had roughly 4,000 of the 4,200 Bitcoin held in its Liquid Federation wallet stolen, it said in a post on X.

BLOOMBERG

**Volcanic ash: 7 Indonesia airports remain shut**  
**TANGERANG:** Seven Indonesian airports, including two serving Jakarta, remained closed on Monday because of volcanic ash from eruptions at Mount Anak Krakatau as around 341,000 travellers were affected by flight cancellations and delays, officials said.

REUTERS

**New Mexico state may become 'New America': Trump**  
**WASHINGTON:** US President Donald Trump's name-changing spree found an unlikely new target on Sunday when he suggested the state of New Mexico could become "New America".

AFP

# AfD's victory tests Germany's 'firewall' against far-right

Associated Press

letters@hindustantimes.com

**BERLIN:** Alternative for Germany (AfD), has established itself as a significant political force in the 13 years since its founding, but it has never been part of any state or federal government. That's a result of what is often called a "firewall" against cooperation with the anti-immigrant, far-right party.

That firewall faces its biggest test after AfD won a landslide victory in Sunday's election in the eastern German state of Saxony-Anhalt.

Germany's mainstream parties have long said they would not work with Alternative for Germany, which is classified by Germany's domestic intelligence agency as an extremist group in some regions of the country — including the eastern state of Saxony-Anhalt. Any dealing by mainstream parties with AfD is particularly sensitive in view of Germany's Nazi past.

AfD has rejected any accusations of being undemocratic or even anti-constitutional and has repeatedly pushed back against the firewall.

The firewall taboo has sometimes forced other parties into unusual alliances to keep AfD out of power — for instance, a three-party coalition straddling ideological divisions that governs the eastern state of Thuringia since AfD emerged as the strongest party for the first time in a regional election there two years ago.

In Germany's national election last year, AfD achieved the best showing by a far-right party since World War II and became the strongest political force in parts of the country. AfD became the biggest opposition party in parliament after Chancellor Friedrich



Ulrich Siegmund (centre), leader in the Saxony-Anhalt state election for AfD, is flanked by his party's federal co-leaders Alice Weidel (right) and Tino Chrupalla (left) at a press conference in Berlin, Germany, on Monday.

AFP



Chancellor Friedrich Merz

Merz's centre-right Christian Democrats upheld the firewall and formed an unpopular coalition with the centre-left Social Democrats.

AfD won 43.8% of the vote in Sunday's election, more than double its showing five years ago in the state, while Merz's party lost about half its support.

Merz has strictly rejected any kind of cooperation with AfD in the past and top officials reiterated that stance on Sunday. But other parties in the newly elected state parliament may be less likely to keep up the firewall.

The AfD candidate for govern-

nor, Ulrich Siegmund, aims to become the first far-right head of a state government and has already said he will reach out to all other parties and individual lawmakers to assemble a governing majority.

While Siegmund has rejected an AfD minority government, his party could possibly govern with the hard-left BSW party, which received 5.3% of the vote. The two parties share a Russia-friendly course and oppose immigration but do not agree on some other subjects.

Political analyst Volker Resing said AfD may be able to overcome the firewall after its strong showing in Saxony-Anhalt, with BSW potentially serving as the kingmaker. "This tiny party could now play a decisive role in determining the future of Saxony-Anhalt," he told The Associated Press.

Resing said "it is still unclear" whether the parties will join forces based on their common view toward Russia to overcome the firewall and succeed in forming Germany's first far-right state government since the end of the Nazi era.

# Saudi Aramco's oil facility on Red Sea coast hit in fresh strikes: Report

Reuters, Bloomberg & AFP

letters@hindustantimes.com

**LONDON/RIYADH:** The Jazan oil refinery, owned by the world's biggest oil company Saudi Aramco, was attacked on Monday and the damage is being ascertained, Reuters reported quoting the Financial Times (FT) reported, citing two people with knowledge of the matter.

In August, Yemen's Houthis claimed to have targeted the refinery in Jazan on the Red Sea coast twice in a week. The group's forces fired two drones at the refinery and hit it, Houthi-controlled Saba news agency reported, citing an unidentified military source. One of the strikes temporarily knocked out some production in the refinery.

The attacks in southwest Saudi Arabia were carried out in response to the kingdom's "violation" of Yemen's airspace and sovereignty in Sa'dah and Hajjah, according to the report.

In July, the Houthis said they

**ISRAEL HITS LEBANON, ACCUSES HEZBOLLAH OF TRUCE VIOLATIONS**

**KFAR RUMMAN, LEBANON:** Israel conducted a wave of deadly airstrikes in south Lebanon, Lebanese state media said on Monday, as it accused Hezbollah of violating a ceasefire agreement that had brought a period of relative calm.

The strikes overnight killed 11 people in a south Lebanon village, including two infants, Lebanon's official National News Agency (NNA) said, a day after separate raids left seven dead.

AFP

**IRAN WARNS AMERICAN ENERGY ASSETS IN GULF VULNERABLE**

**DUBAI:** Iran threatened on Monday to retaliate against any new US attacks on its assets, warning that energy infrastructure across the Gulf, including US oil and gas interests, was vulnerable. "Strike our assets and you get struck," Iranian Parliament Speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf said. Iran has tightened restrictions on shipping through the Strait of Hormuz since the war began with US and Israeli strikes on Feb 28.

REUTERS

Days of fighting near the Red Sea coast have left more than 300 people dead and displaced hundreds of families as the Houthis try to capture land bordering Bab al-Mandab Strait.

**Oil prices near six-week high on US-Iran attacks**

Oil prices were near six-week high on Monday, creeping closer to \$100 a barrel, as tit-for-tat strikes between the US and Iran on vessels sailing in the Strait of Hormuz and other areas kept crude oil flows in the Middle East low.

Brent crude futures rose \$1.03, or 1.1%, to settle at \$97.31 a barrel, after hitting their highest point since July 24 at \$98.06. US West Texas Intermediate crude also hovered near a recent six-week high at \$92.65 a barrel, up 1.3%.

Monday's gains come on top of Brent rising around 8% last week, while WTI was boosted nearly 10% after the US and Iran resumed attacks.

# Pakistan showcases newly acquired Chinese missile system as ties deepen

Bloomberg

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**ISLAMABAD:** Pakistan's military showcased an air defence system in a promotional video that resembles a Chinese platform, potentially signalling another layer to defence cooperation that has deepened since the 2025 India-Pakistan conflict.

Pakistan did not identify the six-wheeled military vehicle with a large rectangular radar array in a promotional video of its weapons released on Monday on its official X account. Features of the vehicle, shown about 28 seconds into the video, resemble China's HQ-17A short-range surface-to-air missile system.

If Pakistan acquired the system, it would mark China's first



A version of the HQ-17 air defence system.

WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

sale of the HQ-17A to the South Asian nation. The Pakistan military and air force, as well as China's Defence Ministry, didn't immediately respond to a request for comment. It is common for footage of foreign purchases of Chinese weapons to

emerge before a public announcement.

The HQ-17A is manufactured by China Aerospace Science and Industry Corporation and was first publicly displayed at the National Day military parade in 2019. The People's Liberation Army has an estimated 200 HQ-17 and 50 HQ-17A systems, according to the International Institute for Strategic Studies.

In the past few years, Serbia and Tajikistan have also acquired the HQ-17AE, an export variant based on the HQ-17A, according to the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute.

Military ties between Pakistan and China drew global attention when Pakistan used Chinese-made J-10C fighter jets in the 2025 India-Pakistan conflict.

# NEPAL HOLDS DAY OF MOURNING AS TOLL TOPS 1,300

**KATHMANDU:** Nepal held a day of mourning on Monday to remember those killed in the August 26 floods, with flags lowered at government offices and families concluding mourning rituals. Monday was the 13th day since the flooding which killed more than 1,300 people in Nepal and Tibet and left some 5,000 missing, including foreigners, according to Nepal's disaster management agency.

In predominantly Hindu Nepal, mourning periods last 13 days, during which close family members stay home and relatives visit to pay their respects. Rituals are held on the final day to pray for the souls of the departed.

The government had declared Monday an official day of mourning and ordered flags at government offices lowered to half-staff.

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# Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES





SPORT

# Inside Antonelli's amazing charge to glory at Monza

Sandip Sikdar

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**NEW DELHI:** The atmosphere at Monza is always thick with history. But on Sunday afternoon, it crackled with something far more electric — destiny. For 60 years, the spirit of Ludovico Scarfiotti had wandered the hallowed asphalt of the 'Temple of Speed' — since 1966 no Italian driver had stood on the top step of the podium at their home Grand Prix.

It was a prolonged drought that for many even felt like a national curse. But curses, as Kimi Antonelli proved in a drive for the ages, are simply waiting for the right generational talent to shatter them.

Starting 19th on the grid after an engine change, victory for the 20-year-old seemed implausible. The grandstands were filled with a hopeful but resigned crowd. Yet, what Antonelli is doing in a Formula 1 car is not surprising anymore, as he continues to display his enormous talent.

Over 53 enthralling laps, Antonelli, leading the drivers' standings, delivered a masterclass in race craft, demonstrating such guile that it left veterans of the paddock speechless. The Mercedes driver wove his way through the pack to claim a victory that will echo through the annals of motorsport history.

When the red lights went out, the back of the grid was chaotic as ever. Despite starting from the rear, Antonelli knew exactly what to do and when. While others scrambled for grip and track position, he was ruthlessly methodical. He picked off cars through the Turn 1 chicane and Curva Grande with the precision of a seasoned champion, slicing his way forward while protecting his car.



The circle marks where Kimi Antonelli started the Italian GP in Monza. PHOTO: F1/X

## Drivers to win F1 races from farthest back on the grid

| STARTING POSITION | DRIVER                  | TEAM         | RACE                  | YEAR |
|-------------------|-------------------------|--------------|-----------------------|------|
| 22nd              | John Watson (GBR)       | McLaren      | United States GP West | 1983 |
| 19th              | Kimi Antonelli (ITA)    | Mercedes     | ITALIAN GRAND PRIX    | 2026 |
| 19th              | Bill Vukovich (USA)     | Kurtis Kraft | Indianapolis 500      | 1954 |
| 18th              | Rubens Barichello (BRA) | Ferrari      | German Grand Prix     | 2000 |
| 17th              | Max Verstappen (NED)    | Red Bull     | Sao Paulo Grand Prix  | 2024 |
| 17th              | Kimi Raikkonen (FIN)    | McLaren      | Japanese Grand Prix   | 2005 |
| 17th              | John Watson (GBR)       | McLaren      | Detroit Grand Prix    | 1982 |

The race, however, was anything but straightforward. It developed into a theater of interruptions. Antonelli had to survive early yellow flags that bunched up the field, a prolonged Virtual Safety Car (VSC) period that threatened his tyre temperatures, and a red flag that completely reset the grid and threatened to wipe out his hard-fought progress.

Each stoppage could have derailed any less-composed driver. Instead, the Italian kept his cool. He used the chaos to his advantage, reading the evolving race differently from the rest of the grid.

Then came the intense, yo-yo racing with Mercedes teammate George Russell. All season long, Antonelli has systematically outpaced and humbled Russell, asserting his dominance within

the garage. Monza turned out to be the ultimate statement of that shifting hierarchy.

As the race restarted after the red flag, Russell found himself squarely in Antonelli's crosshairs. What followed was a brilliant, high-speed chess match. Russell defended, varying his lines and using every ounce of electrical deployment to stay ahead.

But the Italian's spatial awareness and late braking were on another plane. With an overtake before the Ascari chicane on Lap 50, Antonelli left Russell in his wake. To fully grasp the magnitude of this drive, one must look deep into the sport's archives. This was a comeback drive that invites comparisons with the greatest recovery drives in F1 history.

It possessed the relentless, storming charge of Max Verstappen from 14th to first at Spa, Belgium in 2022, the seemingly impossible, penalty-defying surge of Lewis Hamilton at Interlagos, Brazil in 2021, the ice-cold, final-lap heroics of Kimi Raikkonen at Suzuka, Japan in 2005, and the strategic genius of Michael Schumacher coming from 16th to win in the changing conditions of Spa in 1995.

Antonelli's performance borrowed elements from all these legendary drives, synthesising them into a singular, awe-inspiring masterpiece. As the laps ticked down, the impossible materialised into reality. Antonelli coaxed life out of his fading tyres while maintaining blistering pace that no one could match. When he finally took the chequered flag, the roar from the

grandstands was deafening.

Red, white, and green smoke billowed into the Lombardy sky. At just 20, he had delivered a phenomenal drive in his home race, managing the unimaginable with the composure of a veteran.

Antonelli has cemented his name among the absolute elite, now holding the record for most wins (7) by an Italian driver after the legendary Alberto Ascari (13). The 60-year wait is officially over. Scarfiotti's 1966 triumph has finally been emulated by a driving phenomenon in the making.

What we witnessed was the definitive crowning of a new king of Italian motorsport. The boy from Bologna has arrived, after giving the tifosi much to celebrate, and overcome the disappointment of the two Ferrari drivers.

# Carlsen beats an old rival, then held by a rising star

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**BENGALURU:** It is a late Monday afternoon, but inside the 400-odd seater spectators' arena at the Lalit Ashok, there is barely any semblance of a working weekday. Nor is there room for breath. The spectators, headphones on, follow the live commentary at the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League venue, as the moves appear on the board. There is the familiar hush of a chess crowd—hundreds of people watching players move pieces in near silence.

At the centre of it all, under the blinding white lights, sit two old rivals. Thirteen years ago, they met in a World Championship match for the first time. Much has changed since. Viswanathan Anand, 56, currently acting Fide president, is no longer a regular sighting on the tournament circuit. Carlsen, 35, has since stepped away from the World Championship cycle and trimmed his calendar. He still remains world No.1.

Playing White, Anand went for a somewhat rare Sicilian, which Carlsen employed earlier at the World Rapid and Blitz Championship. By move 30, Carlsen seemed to be taking over. The d-file resembled the notorious Hebbal traffic pile-up with Black's bishop pair ready to turn the screws.

Anand managed to defend well and the game seemed headed towards a draw before his clock ran out and he lost on time. "Just a few moves ago, I had a few seconds more than him, so somehow my brain stopped looking at the clock," Anand said after.

"I felt like I was outplaying him in the middlegame and later on I was a bit shaky with little time. For a while he was defending really well, and I resigned myself to a draw. Then I randomly glanced at his clock," Carlsen said.

Carlsen's win wasn't enough



Magnus Carlsen after beating Viswanathan Anand at GCL. GCL

as his side Alpine APL pipers lost to PBG Alaskan Knights 9-7.

The crowd was an assortment of those who'd called in sick from work and school. Among them was eight-year-old Anish Pujar, who had flown in from Munich with his parents to watch the Global Chess League.

"He's the under-8 state chess champion of Bavaria," beamed his mother. "We end up spending our holidays in India at chess tournaments. Last year, it was the Chennai Grand Masters."

Anish calls himself a "Magnus fan" and the family have tickets to the next Carlsen-Anand face-off later this week before they fly back to Germany.

At six in the evening as the crowds swelled outside the playing arena, Carlsen walked in — boards, notebooks, diaries, thrust before him — to play chess' most-talked about player right now, Javokhir Sindarov. The Uzbek will go up against Gukesh in November in the classical world title duel. As Carlsen made his way past fans, someone from the crowd yelled, "Magnus, don't make a draw!"

Roughly an hour later, Carlsen walked out of the playing arena, hair tousled, calling his performance in the league so far

"underwhelming", his play with limited time "not great" and a third draw in four games.

He seemed to have Sindarov gobsmacked with 3...f6. When asked about it later, Carlsen revealed that the move was born out of a mis-click.

"It was originally from my coach. It was a mis-click and we started looking at it. I kind of like the idea that you can take a random move in the opening and, with computer analysis, you can pretty much make anything work. The main idea is that after casting, 4...a6, it's already not terrible."

The queens were traded inside the first 20 moves, and Magnus tried to do Magnus things in the endgame, cranking up the pressure. But he made a mistake with 47...Bb5, and it became a race against the clock. The game eventually ended in a draw, handing Fyers American Gambits a 3-15 loss, the biggest margin of defeat so far this season.

Carlsen praised his opponent. "Sindarov has a very good positional understanding. He is very well-rounded and doesn't have any obvious weaknesses. He certainly put a lot of pressure on me early in the game."

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Stefanos Tsitsipas of Greece returns against Ben Shelton of USA during the fourth round of the US Open in New York on Sunday.

# Single-handed backhand: A 149-year Major streak ends

Stefanos Tsitsipas' US Open exit means no practitioner of the beautiful shot will be in the men's semis

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**MUMBAI:** On social media, a new campaign started after an appeal was made from the Grandstand stadium in the Billie Jean King National Tennis Center in New York. "I'd like to start some sort of movement," said Stefanos Tsitsipas on Saturday. "#Keep-onehanderalive."

Hours later, the Greek would post on his X account: "I've got a 150-year streak to save."

The streak he referred to was this: At least one men's singles player with a one-handed backhand reaching the semi-final of a Grand Slam in each calendar year. The streak had lasted since the Majors began with the 1877 Wimbledon Championships.

On Sunday night, in the stadium named after US tennis legend Arthur Ashe—he used a one-handed backhand—the sequence ended. Tsitsipas was beaten 6-2, 6-3, 6-4 by Ben Shelton in the fourth round of the US Open.

The end of the 149-year streak should not come entirely as a surprise, as more players funneling into the upper echelons of tennis possess the steady two-handed backhand, instead of the flamboyant one-hander. "I think it is partly a consequence of the fact that, realistically, the two-handed backhand offers an advantage in modern tennis," Lorenzo Musetti, the former world No.5 who kept the streak alive at the US Open in 2024 and French Open last year, was quoted as saying by the US Open website. "In terms of efficiency, I think the two-handed backhand is more advantageous with the speed at which tennis is played today."

The sport has become slower because the overall speed of courts has been reduced and the tennis balls too have become heavier. This has caused rallies to become longer and reduced the tendency of players coming up to the net. With the slower speeds, the two-handed provides scope for a slightly bigger margin of error. "The one-hander requires excellent footwork and technique," said Tsitsipas, a two-time Slam finalist, after his second round at the US Open. "That is the only downside (compared to) a double-handed backhand. I feel like with a double-handed backhand you can always save the situation, if you're a bit

## KEY RESULTS (FOURTH ROUND)

**MEN:** Frances Tiafoe (USA x11) bt Daniil Medvedev (RUS x7) 7-6 (7/1), 6-4, 7-6 (8/6); Alex Michelsen (USA) bt Tomas Etcheverry (ARG x27) 7-6 (8/6), 6-4, 6-4; Ben Shelton (USA x8) bt Stefanos Tsitsipas (GRE) 6-2, 6-3, 6-4; Carlos Alcaraz (ESP x2) bt Tommy Paul (USA x20) 6-4, 6-3, 6-4

**WOMEN:** Aryna Sabalenka (BLR x1) bt Taylor Townsend (USA) 6-4, 6-3; Linda Nosková (CZE x6) bt Marta Kostyuk (UKR x11) 7-5, 5-7, 6-4; Jessica Pegula (USA x3) bt Sorana Cirstea (ROM x16) 6-3, 6-4; Emma Navarro (USA x26) bt Anna Kalinskaya (RUS x21) 6-4, 6-2; Mirra Andreeva (RUS x5) bt Anastasia Potapova (RUS x24) 5-7, 6-4, 6-3; Zheng Qinwen (CHN) bt Iga Swiatek (POL x8) 7-5, 6-3

late or out of position you can always use your left hand to sort of 'scoop' it in. There is no such thing with a one-handed backhand. If you're late, you're late. You missed the train."

Once a staple and now an aberration, the one-handed backhand's decline has been steady across decades. In the 1969 calendar year, the first full season played in the Open Era, all four semi-finalists in each of the four Majors used one-handers. In 2000, 14-time Grand Slam champion Pete Sampras was the only one-hander in the Australian Open semi-finals, Franco Squillari and Gustavo Kuerten reached the last four at the French Open, Sampras and Pat Rafter were semi-finalists at Wimbledon, and Sampras alone reached the last four in New York.

This season, based on the current rankings, no top 10 ATP player

uses a one-handed backhand. Going back to the US Open in 2006, four in the top 10 – Roger Federer, Ivan Ljubicic, Tommy Robredo and James Blake used the one-hander.

Federer, a 20-time Grand Slam winner whose backhand has been revered for its balletic beauty and accuracy, had kept the streak alive for many years. "My coaches when I was growing up were, I would say, 90 percent one-handers," he said in a press conference during the US Open Fan Week. "So, when your coach is a one-handed player, you will most likely be a one-handed player too. Nowadays, probably the coaches are mostly double-handed players, and it's just easier to teach a kid to have two hands on the backhand side."

To tackle the changing speed of the courts, Federer in 2014 changed his racquet from a

90-square-inch frame to 97 inches, allowing him a bigger striking zone and the option to attack earlier. There are still a few who choose the one-hander. Rising star Lilli Tagger, an 18-year-old from Austria who won the junior French Open last year, was allowed to play with the one-handed backhand after she won a bet against her coach as junior.

The world No.49 is now one of only four women's singles players in the top 100 using the one-hander – Diane Parry, Viktorija Golubic and Tatjana Maria are the others. Tagger now trains in an academy run by Francesca Schiavone, the last women's singles player to win a Grand Slam (French Open 2010) using the one-handed backhand.

Among men, the last player to win a Slam with the one-hander was Dominic Thiem in the 2020 US Open. There are six men in the top 100 using that stroke – Musetti, Tsitsipas, Denis Shapovalov, Daniel Altmaier, Giovanni Mpetshi Perricard and Aleksandar Kovacevic. When Swiss three-time Slam winner Stan Wawrinka retires in a few months, there will no longer be an active major winner with a one-handed backhand.

"Every single decade, we are degrading. We are like dinosaurs going extinct," Tsitsipas said.

## Kishan's 270 second-best score in Duleep Trophy final

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**KOLKATA:** There are innings that announce themselves, and then there are innings that quietly alter the conversation around a player. Ishan Kishan's 270—second highest score in a Duleep Trophy final—for East Zone against South Zone at Chepauk on Monday belonged to the latter category.

On a hot, humid Chennai afternoon, with the pitch neither offering extravagant movement nor easy pace on Day 2 of the five-day match, Kishan did something that has increasingly become unfashionable in the age of instant cricket—he stayed, and then stayed some more. Till he had carved out an innings to remember, with partner Kumar Kushagra helping himself to a hundred as well.

"Being an established part of the squad, I feel it is crucial that I take up the primary role of scoring runs and making sure the team's total climbs because of me," Kishan said.

By the time he reached 250, Kishan had faced 300 balls, his innings containing 27 fours and seven sixes. It was an extraordinary combination of accumulation and aggression, sort of performance that demanded both patience and a willingness to exploit scoring opportunities. Most importantly, it was a statement of intent. East were 708 all out when stumps were called.

The 28-year-old East skipper has never needed reminding that he can hit a cricket ball. His white-ball credentials have long been obvious. The more interesting question has been whether he wants, and is prepared, to do the less glamorous work required in first-class cricket—leaving the ball, absorbing pressure, batting through fatigue and building an innings in layers. At the MA Chidambaram Stadium, he supplied emphatic answers.

His first 150 came off 204 balls (19x4, 1x6). It was an innings built largely on control rather than spectacle. With the South attack

| Duleep Trophy final top scores |           |
|--------------------------------|-----------|
| RAMAN LAMBA                    | 320 RUNS  |
| FOR NORTH VS WEST (1987)       |           |
| ISHAN KISHAN                   | 270 RUNS  |
| FOR EAST VS SOUTH (2026)       |           |
| YASHASVI JAISWAL               | 265 RUNS  |
| FOR WEST VS SOUTH (2022)       |           |
| CHETESHWAR PUJARA              | 256* RUNS |
| FOR IND BLUE VS IND RED (2016) |           |

made to bowl long spells in oppressive conditions, Kishan resisted the temptation to manufacture shots. He defended when the ball demanded it and scored when bowlers strayed. Then came the acceleration.

He moved from 150 to 200 in 66 balls, adding boundaries as he began to use his feet against the spinners. Leg spinner Shreyas Gopal, who had already bowled a demanding spell, was repeatedly challenged down the ground. Off-spinner Tripurana Vijay was driven, swept and lofted. Kishan was no longer simply seeing off the bowling. He was manipulating the deliveries.

The most revealing aspect of the innings was the way he dealt with spin. Rather than allowing the bowlers to dictate the tempo, Kishan repeatedly came down the pitch, got to the pitch of the ball and hit through the line. A six over cow corner, another launched over long-off, and a series of drives through the off side showed that he had worked out where the danger lay, and where the runs were.

There was a physical cost. By the second session, Kishan was feeling the effects of the long stay. He stretched his hamstring, occa-

sionally refused singles and, after being struck painfully while attempting a pull, needed attention from the physio. Even then the innings retained its peculiar rhythm—defend, wait, attack.

At 250, he raised his bat and absorbed the applause, soon deciding to retire hurt.

He returned and a triple hundred was in sight, but Kishan was superbly caught by R Smaran at long on.

Kishan missed out on that deserved milestone but for a player whose future has often been discussed through the prism of limited-overs cricket, the significance of this innings lies less in the number itself than in the manner of its construction.

Chepauk demanded patience before it rewarded aggression, and Kishan embraced the challenge. In Chennai's heat, Kishan did not merely score 270, he made a remarkably persuasive case for why he should be judged as a first-class cricketer again.

For the record, he has a first-class top score of 273. **Brief scores:** East Zone 708 all out (A Easwaran 72, S Mohan 85, I Kishan 270, K Kushagra 101, T Vijay 4/180, C Milind 2/88, S Gopal 2/165) v South Zone



## Bengal backs Paes for AITA president

**NEW DELHI:** Leander Paes is set to enter the race for the presidency of the All India Tennis Association, with the Bengal Tennis Association (BTA) deciding to back his candidature, setting up a potential contest against Davis Cup skipper Rohit Rajpal. BTA has made up its mind but Paes first needs to win the impending Sports Person of Outstanding Merit (SOM) election to stand as presidential candidate.

## Messi-Ronaldo for Tevez farewell match?

**BUENOS AIRES:** Carlos Tevez said Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo will share the pitch as teammates in his farewell match scheduled to be held at Boca Juniors' iconic La Bombonera in December, according to Goal.com. Tevez said he had received the agreement of both Messi and Ronaldo. "I have always dreamed of seeing Cristiano and Leo playing in one team," Tevez said in televised comments.

## Modric in squad for Nations League

**ZAGREB:** Luka Modric was named by coach Slaven Bilic in the Croatia squad for the Nations League. When Croatia plays at Czech Republic on Sept. 26, Modric will earn his 203rd cap at age 41. In July he signed up for one more club season with AC Milan. Only Cristiano Ronaldo has more internationals (233) and Lionel Messi who announced his retirement a week ago had 207.

## 'We trusted our defence, were patient in attack'

Sandip Sikdar

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**NEW DELHI:** The China Masters triumph has given India's star doubles duo Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty a surge of momentum heading into the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, which starts on September 19.

Capturing their second title of the season after winning the Singapore Open in May, they weathered a gruelling week in Shenzhen, coming through four three-game thrillers across five matches to prove their physical and tactical resilience right before they begin their Asian Games title defence.

"It definitely gives us a huge confidence boost going into the Asian Games, especially after having a tough few months being away from the court. It definitely gives us a boost that the thing that we are doing is actually working. We've got some really good match practice as well," Chirag said in a media call facilitated by the Badminton Association of India (BAI) on Monday.

The performance marked a turnaround after their frustrating outing at the New Delhi World Championships where a lack of court time proved costly as they lost in the quarter-finals. In Shenzhen, adapting physically was the key as their bodies "settled down and got better".

"At the Worlds, we didn't really get a lot of court time whereas we played five matches here. Barring the first round, we played four three-game matches. And yet the body feels a lot better than what it was at the World Championships," said Chirag.

Tactically, the duo demonstrated refinement and discipline, learning to grind it out



Satwiksairaj Rankireddy (L) and Chirag Shetty.

through long rallies rather than rely purely on force. Asked about their tactical flexibility when their aggressive game hit a wall, Satwik offered a characteristic response: "It's always Plan A for us. There's no Plan B. But Chirag makes my job much easier. He creates so many chances for me to finish."

Chirag elaborated: "One of the major things we incorporated from the World Championships is to be patient while we are attacking and to trust our defence. We weren't in a hurry to finish it when we got those lifts and were quite sure of what strokes to play," said Chirag.

Satwik said that even without peak power, their basic game held firm. "Even without our A weapons, we are playing at a high level. Even though I wasn't able to smash 100%, still we are troubling top players," he added.

Constant technical evolution remains central to their success. Chirag highlighted how Satwik surprised opponents who tried

to target his serve, which has traditionally been his Achilles heel. "Satwik was able to keep it low, which took them by surprise. When you're able to do that, you keep your opponents guessing because they don't really know what is going to hit them," said Chirag.

## Burden of expectations

Next up is the Asian Games where, apart from defending the title, they also go in with the reputation as the only Indians to have won a badminton gold in the continental games. The pair, which came up trumps in Hangzhou in 2023, downplayed any burden of expectation.

"A lot of people will say that we are the pair to beat. I wouldn't say that. There are plenty of other good pairs as well. We just want to go out there and have as much fun as we normally do. When we are able to keep the results aside and take one match at a time, we do really well," said Chirag.



China's Qinwen Zheng. REUTERS

## QUALIFIER ZHENG SHOCKS SWIATEK TO REACH QUARTERS

Agencies

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**NEW YORK:** Olympic gold medalist Zheng Qinwen, who had to come through US Open qualifying, stunned six-time Grand Slam champion Iga Swiatek 7-5, 6-3 to reach the quarter-finals.

It was another gritty win for the Chinese star, a former world number four now ranked 121st in the wake of elbow surgery last year. Zheng won the last seven games to stun Madison Keys in her previous match. After falling behind 5-0 in the first set against Swiatek she again reeled off seven straight.

She broke the Polish star twice in the second set to clinch the win.

Fifth-seeded French Open champion Mirra Andreeva of Russia shook off a slow start to beat Anastasia Potapova 5-7, 6-4 6-3. Andreeva, who had won her three previous matches in straight sets, dropped the first set after committing more than twice as many unforced errors as Potapova, who was also born in Russia but now plays for Austria.

But the 19-year-old steadied herself, notching fewer errors in the final two sets against Potapova. In a dramatic final game, Potapova lost her footing leaning for a shot, falling to the ground and writhing in pain.

## Strong fencing squad eyes medal breakthrough at the Asian Games

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**NEW DELHI:** When Shreya Gupta took up fencing, she trained on the stairs of a cricket stadium in Jammu. Prachi Lohan, from Jind, Haryana, had to share weapons during her initial days. Both promising talents are now part of India's 20-member fencing contingent—the biggest ever the country will send to the Asian Games in Japan.

Fencing is a sport where India have been looking to make inroads in recent years, considering the number of medals at stake at the Olympics. At the Paris Games, fencing had 12 medal events—six each for men and women. Bhavani Devi's qualification in sabre for 2021 Tokyo was a breakthrough and several junior fencers have shown promise since then.

Things have changed significantly domestically. A decade ago, there was hardly any facility or knowledge about the sport. But with government funding and resources being pooled in, Indian fencers have made steady progress at the junior and sub-junior international levels.

This year, Prachi and Taniksha Khatri became the first Indian women's epee fencers to reach the main table of 64 at the Senior World Fencing Championships in Hong Kong. The results at the recent Commonwealth Championships were also encouraging. The men's foil team finished eighth at the Asian Championships in New Delhi recently.

The Asian Games, therefore, present a big opportunity for the fencers to make an impact. India have not won a medal in fencing at the Asian Games. At the previous edition, Taniksha's run in epee ended in the quarter-finals, one step away from at least a bronze medal.

"This time we are prepared to have a crack," says chief coach



Fencers (from L) Kanupriya Chawla, Taniksha Khatri, Prachi Lohan and Joys Ashitha Stalinraj.

Sagar Lagu. "The competition in Asia is very strong. In fact, Asia is dominating the world if you look at the results at the Paris Olympics. So, for our teams to be in the top eight in Asia is a good indicator," says the senior coach, who laid a strong foundation for Bhavani Devi at SAI centre in Thalassery. Bhavani is part of the squad.

Eight men and 12 women have been selected for the Games. India will compete in team events—men's foil and sabre, and women's sabre, epee and foil—besides the individual competitions.

At Paris, Japan topped the fencing medal tally with five medals, while South Korea and Hong Kong finished third and fourth, respectively. Prachi says the facilities at home are now top-class and have helped the fencers develop. The Indian team has been preparing at the newly built High Performance

Centre for Fencing at NIS Patiala, which came up this year at a cost of ₹22.83 crore. The centre has an indoor fencing hall equipped with international-standard pistes and electronic scoring systems. Sports science support, advanced strength and conditioning and recovery facilities are well integrated in the centre.

"Fencing is much more popular now. When I started fencing, we did not have much equipment. We did not have the electronic scoring system at my club. The weapons were limited and we used to share. Two years into the sport, around COVID time, the infrastructure started getting a little better. And then Khelo India helped us financially because it is an expensive sport," says Prachi.

The 20-year-old is buoyed after her impressive showing at World Championships. "It was an amaz-

ing experience to qualify for the main table (draw). It has given me a lot of confidence. I have been working since then for the Asian Games," says the epee fencer.

Foreign exposure trips have also increased. Through TOPS, Shreya and other fencers have travelled to Hungary to train under three-time Olympic champion Aron Szilagyi. "If we compare, say, 10 years back, we are improving but we have to improve a lot. There is support from SAI, federation (FAI) etc. The more exposure and training we get, the more we will improve."

The path shown by Bhavani, a sabre fencer, has been inspirational. "She is always motivating us," says Shreya. "We have played together in events. And even when we lose, she is always like, 'You have to give your best, irrespective of the opponent or rankings.'"